THE GILGAMESH PROJECT

BOOK III LA VILLA CONTESSA

JOHN FRANCIS KINSELLA

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for

Tilla, Selma, Eléonore, Noé, Xaver, Elyas, Adèle, Camille and Antoine

W. Somerset Maugham once said, “There are three rules for writing a novel. Unfortunately, no one knows what they are.”

Out where the river broke
The bloodwood and the desert oak
Holden wrecks and boiling diesels
Steam in forty-five degrees
The time has come to say fair's fair
To pay the rent, to pay our share
The time has come, a fact's a fact
It belongs to them, let's give it back

Hirst, Moginie & Garrett

Unreal City,

Under the brown fog of a winter dawn,
A crowd flowed over London Bridge, so many,
I had not thought death had undone so many.
Sighs, short and infrequent, were exhaled,
And each man fixed his eyes before his feet.
Flowed up the hill and down King William Street,
To where Saint Mary Woolnoth kept the hours
With a dead sound on the final stroke of nine.
There I saw one I knew, and stopped him, crying: ‘Stetson!
‘You who were with me in the ships at Mylae!
‘That corpse you planted last year in your garden,
‘Has it begun to sprout? Will it bloom this year?
‘Or has the sudden frost disturbed its bed?
‘Oh keep the Dog far hence, that’s friend to men,
‘Or with his nails he’ll dig it up again!
‘You! hypocrite lecteur!—mon semblable,—mon frère!’

TS Eliot

CHAPTER 1

PAT KENNEDY OPENED HIS EYES, then slowly examined his surroundings, he recognised his room at the Villa Contessa and felt a surge of immense pleasure. A month had passed since he had decided to isolate himself, like many of the very rich, far from the crowds, the stress of meetings and the constant hustle of the City of London.

He bounded out of bed, stretched, picked up the remote and zapped open the roller shutters of his large high ceilinged bedroom. The sun streamed in from the southwest, it was another early summer morning.

Pat shaded his eyes and admired the magnificent view over the terrace, the Mediterranean sparkled like a silver platter beyond the villa's luxuriant gardens.

He felt good.

Life was very good, far from Boris Johnson's fatuous 'Let's get going' Britain.

What had been planned as a rest in Beaulieu-sur-mer was now becoming a habit. He had little desire to return to London, even less Hong Kong. He just wanted to lay back, admire the colours and breath in the perfumes of the French Riviera.

But to start the day he had an appointment at Lifegen, for his first check-up and at breakfast he informed George, his butler cum household manager, he would drive to Sophia Antipolis himself and return after lunch with Rob McGoldrick.

He'd never felt so well, relaxed, being far from the pressures of London, Paris and Hong Kong was having its effect.

Rob McGoldrick had always reminded Pat that good health was primordial, keeping a toned muscle structure for as long as possible not only helped to preserve mobility in later life, it also improved the aesthetics of ageing, helped maintain the firmness of the face and body, keeping him looking fit and youthful.

However, that was not all, it was also essential to feel good, build a positive view of life, which started with a diet to improve cardiovascular health, reduce cholesterol levels, lessen the risks of osteoarthritis. Starting with a plant based diet and eating less meat and animal based products.

Pat had learnt that the skin was a great indicator of health, that a diet of fresh fruit and vegetables improved the complexion, healing and moisturising the skin, making for a younger appearance, boosting that feel-good sense of contentment.

It was why when he looked at his reflection in his bathroom mirror, he felt pleased with what he saw, his smooth skin and the glow a healthy tan gave. On Rob's recommendations he had spent his time relaxing by the pool and enjoying just enough sun. But there was something else. He looked more closely at his skin, it seemed firmer, clearer. He stretched his cheek with

his fingers. There was no mistaking it, he definitely looked younger.

He picked up his cellphone, glanced at the messages, checked the biometric data on his Apple Watch, a GPS+Cellular. Everything looked in order, all details were transmitted to the LifeGen site via a direct link, open 24/24, where his data was monitored in real-time.

Looking at his cell and watch, the idea occurred to him that he and those around him were evolving into cyborgs of a kind, which didn't worry him more than that.

After dressing, Pat skipped down the broad marble stairway and through the open French windows onto the villa's terrace, where he paused to eat a freshly prepared fruit salad. He then headed for the garage situated behind the gardens under the shade of a tall stand of cypresses where his driver was waiting. He wished Pat good morning and handed him the keys of the car that was already parked on the gravel driveway.

With no more ado Pat slid in behind the wheel of the burgundy coloured 1967 Citroen DS cabriolet, his favorite, one he felt went with the style of the villa. He had always been fascinated by the Côte d'Azur and the people who had lived there—Picasso, Van Gogh, Grace Kelly, Coco Chanel and especially Scott Fitzgerald. He liked to imagine himself in the role of one of the writer's literary heroes.

Heading off along the winding road he breathed in the morning air before he hit La Provençale—the winding

autoroute that would take him around Nice and on to Valbonne and the Sophia Antipolis Science Park.

Forty five minutes later he was at LifeGen where his friend, Rob, was just arriving after having taken a taxi directly from Nice airport.

‘Hi Pat, how are you,’ said Rob smiling. ‘Like the car. The Mediterranean air must be doing you good, you’re looking in great form.’

Pat grinned, he was feeling good.

Michel Morel appeared at the smoked glass doors that led into the reception area of the futuristic research centre. He looked pleased to see his friends. ‘Let’s go to the conference room, Jean-Yves is waiting for us.’

Standing before an extra large flat TV screen at one end of the conference room Jean-Yves was juggling with various images from a laptop.

‘Hi guys, I’m just trying to get these pictures in the right order.’

They sat down around the oval table facing the screen exchanging small talk as a secretary oversaw the coffee served by an attractive assistant in a white coat.

‘So,’ commenced Michel Morel looking at Pat, ‘let’s get down to business. How’s our laboratory primate doing.’

They all laughed.

‘Great, I’m feeling great.’

‘That’s good news, no side effects?’

‘Nothing visible,’ said Pat laying his hand of the table. ‘Touch wood.’

‘Excellent. Jean-Yves is going to run through the data comparison with that Rob supplied us, together with the blood tests and scans made in Beaulieu at the end of last week.’

There was nothing amiss, the data confirmed what they had expected, not only was their ‘primate’ was in perfect form, he was bursting with health.

After Pat was given a clean bill of health they skipped lunch and together with Rob he bid his friends at LifeGen goodbye.

Dropping his bags into the boot Rob jumped into the cabriolet beside Pat who with a hoot of the horn accelerated off in the direction of Nice and the road back to Beaulieu. Rob was looking forward to his break, delighted to get away from the dismal summer weather in London, taking in the silky warmth of the Mediterranean air and easy going life of the Riviera as Pat’s guest for the weekend.

Pat felt elated as he sped along the Corniche, radiating his pleasure with life, not only was his body in good health, but a burden had been lifted from his mind and he could turn his attention to other issues that were important to him.

The initial tests had shown he had new vitality, naturally it would require further, deeper, scientific cell analysis, but it seemed certain that the Galenus formulation had significantly boosted his drive, his verve.

After Rob was shown to his room Pat proposed a game of tennis, then, after a couple of sets, they passed the afternoon relaxing by the pool before driving into Nice to find a place to eat in the Old Town.

Rob was astonished by the change that had taken place in his friend, he seemed so brash, carefree, and he actually looked younger.

* * *

The following morning, looking from his first floor window, Pat was greeted by a familiar grey form in the distance. Anchored a few cables from the entrance to the small harbour, floating on the azure waters of the bay, was *Las Indias*, Pat's yacht, all 90 metres of it.

He went down for breakfast, set out on the terrace under the early morning sun. From the balustrade overlooking the pool he observed Rob McGoldrick swimming, racking up the lengths with a lazy crawl as he did each morning whenever he came down to the villa. He was in good form, a firm believer in a healthy existence, based on regular exercise and a healthy diet. He was a dedicated advocate of life extension.

A few minutes later Rob arrived at the breakfast table in his bathrobe.

‘How are you feeling this morning Pat?’

‘Excellent, never felt better.’

‘I see your yacht is here.’

‘Yes, getting prepared for the clan’s summer cruise, to Egypt, with John and Ekaterina. Anna and Padraig will be joining us. Why don’t you come along?’

‘I wish I could, I’ve got a lot on at the moment in London.’

‘So what do you think about the results? You know, our Galenus molecule?’

‘Ah, Galenus and his friend Telephus.’

Pat frowned, it confused him when people talked in riddles.

‘Well Galenus was an ancient Greek physician and Telephus a grammarian who live to be 100 years old.’

‘Well apart from the history lesson Rob.’

McGoldrick laughed.

‘I have to admit it’s looking positive, very positive, but we’ll have to do a lot more tests on other subjects.’

‘Subjects?’

‘Yes, people.’

‘We mustn’t forget this is all very confidential, strictly confidential, we’ve invested a lot of money and besides that we don’t want the hoi polloi living forever.’

‘I don’t think Galenus would approve of that.’

‘Jesus, be serious for a minute Rob.’

‘I’m sorry Pat. Well what do you suggest next?’

‘I’d like to suggest we ask John to try it. He’s getting on now and not only is he a very good friend, he’s valuable to us.’

‘Well looking at you I don’t think there’s any toxicity risk,’ Rob said laughing, ‘why not, why don’t we speak with Michel and Jean-Yves.’

‘Whilst we’re at it I’d like a couple of months supply for John and myself, we can test it on our Egyptian trip.’

‘Okay, I’m not against that, you should get the team LifeGen to work on it.’

CHAPTER 2

THE YEAR HAD STARTED BADLY when the news from the Mainland worsened, the virus was fanning out from Wuhan like wildfire and the economy was about to grind to a standstill transforming Hollywoodian images of Contagion into reality.

Panic had broken out in Hong Kong as rumours spread across the web and consumers rushed to buy staple foods, border crossing points with the Mainland were closed, airlines slashed flights in and out of the territory, port authorities closed terminals and cruise ships were quarantined.

Cathay, Virgin, American, United, British and Air France joined the list of companies that suspended links to Hong Kong and China.

Supermarket shelves were empty as not only had masks disappeared, but basic foodstuffs like rice and ready to eat noodles were running out fast.

Hotels emptied, tourist arrivals came to a halt, shopping malls were deserted and trade dived, transforming the epidemic into the worse health crisis since 2003, when the city was hit by the Sars epidemic.

It couldn’t have been worse coming hot on the heels of the Democracy demonstrations, a full scale recession was

descending on the city as economists slashed their growth forecasts with consumer spending and tourism going into free fall.

Fears that it could get much worse grew if the spread of the virus was not brought under control and a Wuhan type situation developed with a full scale lockdown.

Soon the whole region was impacted as the flow of Chinese tourists to Thailand dried up, a country whose tourist arrivals had grown to 2.7% of GDP from China alone.

According to scientists at the University of Macau, there were striking differences between the Sars virus of 2003 and the Wuhan Coronavirus: 'The first case in both incidents appeared around December; both local governments involved—Guangzhou and Wuhan, concealed information on the epidemic, both local governments falsely claimed the viruses were not infectious or claimed there was no human-to-human transmission, both local governments held large gatherings with tens of thousands people involved during the critical early transmission period, and both incidents concerned the illegal sale of live wildlife in foodmarkets, to which authorities had turned a blind eye.

The first case was reported in Wuhan on December 31. Within a week 60 suspected cases were declared and one person had died.

Yes it's going to be a fucking blood bath, Pat had told himself, and it was just the beginning, but there was still time to get out.

That evening Pat, Lili and the two children boarded his Gulfstream, and soon they were heading heading west into the night for the eleven hour flight to London. There they would be safe at their home on Cheney Walk, near their friends, their clan, where they would wait until the disease had run its course.

At the outset the British public was flippantly informed that the health authorities were ready as Boris Johnson offered his homespun advise: 'The best thing you can do is to wash your hands with soap and hot water while singing Happy Birthday twice.'

He even suggested that herd immunity was the best route, in spite of the fact the virus was now rampaging through Italy and Spain.

'Perhaps you could take it on the chin, take it all in one go and allow coronavirus to move through the population without really taking as many draconian measures,' he said during a television interview, adding, 'It's only a mild to moderate illness'.

He hadn't calculated he would end up being amongst the first to be infected, plunging blindly on with his Brexit plans after the UK had officially quit the EU at the end of January.

Heedlessly, he set out his government's policy before a distinguished audience in London, describing himself as 'a campaigner for global free trade', then shifting to the subject of what would be soon declared a pandemic, 'we are starting to hear some bizarre autarkic rhetoric ... there is a risk that new diseases such as coronavirus will trigger a panic and a desire for market segregation,' whatever that meant, 'that go beyond what is medically rational to the point of doing real and unnecessary economic damage ....'

He concluded by declaring, 'in all humility that the UK is ready...to take on the role of global leader in free trade'.

Pat had listened to the speech and concluded, Johnson must be out of his wee feekin mind. It was evident that he lived on another planet as the world braced itself for greatest health crisis since the Spanish Flu pandemic of 1918.

Five months fast forward and the UK with the USA were amongst the most affected by the pandemic as their leaders stumbled around, pouring scorn on common sense whilst preaching their Neoliberal principals, hollowing out public services and underfunding health care.

During this time, Bojo's strange chief of staff Dominic Cummings declared, according to the Sunday Times, 'Herd immunity, protect the economy and if that means some pensioners die, too bad.'

As the death rate rose, the economy tanked, the UK's younger generation partied and truncheon wielding police were

dispatched to breakup the fun—in an authoritarian crackdown reminiscent of Belarusia's reaction to those who refused to knuckle under.

From London Pat observed China, which after decades of extraordinary growth and increased prosperity, was confronted by the unimaginable. Of all scenarios, neither Pat nor his advisors could have predicted such a crisis, a textbook black swan event.

At the dawn of the third millennium the world had changed for the better, governments could no longer turn a blind eye to death and famine as they had in the past. China could no longer accept the kind of policies it had known under Mao during the Cultural Revolution, when the Hong Kong flu pandemic was estimated to have killed between one and four million people.

Those days were gone, today with the speed of the internet, smart phones and social media, news travelled at the speed of light compared to 1968, when the pandemic made little political impact and was soon forgotten.

CHAPTER 3

THE KENNEDYS SPENT THE EVENING at John's place, a few houses down the road, where Ekaterina had organised a buffet dinner for close friends, their clan, amongst whom were Padraig and Anna, in London for the weekend, forgetting the Coronavirus and politics, talking about their own projects.

Anna bubbled over as she informed them Spain and Mexico had at long last signed a memorandum of understanding concerning the search for the *Nuestra Señora del Juncal*, a treasure ship that had sunk in a storm in October 1631, on its return voyage to Spain loaded with more than one hundred tons of gold and jewellery.

She told the story of how just 39 of the 300 persons aboard had survived the storm to tell the story of the tragedy.

Anna, an underwater archaeologist, had been invited to join the team of Spanish experts who would participate in the search for the *Juncal*, a project that had been the object of two decades of research and discussion, at last finalised when Spain and Mexico concluded the agreement on their common underwater cultural heritage.

As a consultant for Spain's National Underwater Archaeology Museum, Anna had worked closely with its equivalent, Mexico's National Institute of Anthropology and History. Her experience with the excavation and recovery of the *Espiritu Santo* would be invaluable plus the fact Pat Kennedy had

offered the use of *Las Indias* and his salvage company with the *Sundaland II* for the operations.

It was then the turn of Scott Fitznorman who had just returned from Cairo. He enthused about the new billion dollar Grand Egyptian Museum, scheduled to open later in the year with nearly 100,000 objects on display, including some 5,000 from Tutankhamen's tomb.

He told them that more than 90% of the construction work was completed and a great many artefacts had been transferred to the new site at Giza.

It was late when Pat and Lili returned to their place on Cheney Walk, just a few minutes away. As Pat opened the door his phone buzzed. It was Angus calling from Hong Kong.

'Have you see the news Pat?'

'No,' he replied.

'The shit's hit the fan Pat.'

'What?' exclaimed Pat wondering what he was talking about.

'Switch on Bloomberg. The market's gone wild, selling everything.'

'How come?'

'The Saudis have started a price war with Russia, the Crown Prince is flooding the markets, undercutting prices.'

‘They want to strangle shale oil.’

‘Right.’

‘I’ll speak to Sergei.’

Pat went to his office, zapped his Bloomberg. Red was flashing everywhere. Oil had plunged 34.54%, markets were by a frenzy of panic selling with Footsie futures down 8,63%. Gold was up to 1700 dollars.

‘Okay Angus, have you spoken to Liam?’

‘Not yet.’

‘I’ve just left him. I’ll call him. He won’t be home yet.’

‘Fine.’

‘Don’t panic. I’ll get into the bank early with Liam. Collect all the info you can and we’ll set up a video conference to decide what’s next.’

It was nearly three in the morning when Pat turned in, setting the alarm for six when he would head into the bank’s HQ at the Gould Tower in the City.

He had difficulty sleeping as he feared the tipping point was at hand, with a market crash added to a pandemic what happened next was anyone’s guess, the market was in uncharted territory, was this the moment he feared, the moment he had planned for but hoped would never happen.

As he fell into a restless sleep Vincent van Gogh's 'Wheatfield with Crows' drifted into his dreams, the crows reassembled black swans, it was the artists last painting before he shot himself, 'feekin black swans,' he mumbled to himself, looking up at the dark sky, above a wind swept cornfield, cut by a road leading to nowhere. Black swans—a market crash, a pandemic, he tried to figure out what the others were—the bankruptcy of American shale oil producers, transport disrupted, factories closed, stalled consumption, economic collapse, what happened then was anyone's guess.

Saudi Arabia and Russia could weather the storm as the demand for oil dropped vertiginously and prices collapsed. Some ecologists thought it would change the way fossil fuels were consumed, but what of the small oil producing nations, their revenues would collapse, tens, hundreds of thousands would lose their jobs when exports stalled. Countries like Nigeria and Angola would be strangled and social order would collapse.

There was a rush to liquidity as fear stalked the markets, to cover margin calls and dump travel linked stocks. It was strange there was no rush to gold and government debt, instead the rush was into cash. They were facing what John warned was extreme market dislocation.

John feared a total lockdown, but he consoled himself by recalling the Bard had quarantined himself during plague outbreaks whilst writing King Lear.

CHAPTER 4

A COUPLE OF MONTHS AFTER the Kennedys precipitously quit Hong Kong, Pat tested positive for Covid-19. The symptoms were mild, nothing more than a case of seasonal flu and he self-quarantined in his vast London home where he could enjoy the garden during the fine weather that had coincided with the pandemic in London.

Another month passed, but the sensation of breathlessness and a vague sense of fatigue persisted. He called Robert McGoldrick, a close friend and an eminent neurologist at London University Hospital, who arranged a visit to a specialist at UCLPartners for Pat—a general check-up plus a lung and brain scan.

The result was not great, more tests were needed, McGoldrick putting on a professional face told him not to worry and suggested he take some rest, lightheartedly recommending Nice where he could visit LifeGen.

Pat wondered what that meant, he’d never suffered health problems and rarely visited doctors except to fulfill the annual obligation to his bank that required the CEO and other senior officers undergo a health check.

He was well built, six foot, and played racket sports regularly, he didn't smoke or drink, apart from a very occasional glass of wine at a dinner or a function. At first Pat shrugged it off, but as

the idea that he was perhaps not in perfect health sunk in—with all that that implied, he began to realise there existed a possibility he would never see his long term plans develop, even worse was the thought that perhaps he would not see his two young children grow up.

It was like a slow motion crash. Fate had played him a bad hand, with all his wealth he came to the realisation he would suffer the same fate as that of millions of ordinary people, the vast majority of whom could never—even in their wildest dreams, have imagined the kind of wealth and power he possessed.

Pat didn't need to ask his friend to keep the news confidential and told Lili he would be visiting LifeGen at Sophia Antipolis, suggesting she join him with the children at the Villa Contessa, their home in Beaulieu-sur-Mer, a change from the depressing mood in London.

It was a good moment to head for the Mediterranean sun as Boris Johnson and his government mired the country in a crisis largely of their own making, one that transformed hospitals and emergency services into the setting for an apocalyptic movie as the virus spread, whilst the WHO compounded the drama by frightening the shit out of those who followed the news, warning the world the Coronavirus could be 'Disease X', a pandemic that would wreak havoc, one that could kill tens of millions.

The same day the number of cases in Italy rocketed and financial markets panicked, the country's MIB Index dropped a whopping 6%, the VIX shot up 8% the following day, gold rose to a seven-year high, and oil prices plunged. By the time Wall Street closed that same evening the Dow Jones marked its third worse point drop in the Street's history.

The crash came after Wall Street's main stock indexes had risen to record highs on a wave of New Year optimism that the global economy would continue on its unswerving upward path.

More than one trillion dollars had been wiped off world stock markets in the space of 24 hours after Italy's industrial heartlands—Lombardy and Veneto went into lockdown. Juventus football club shares fell 11% before trading was suspended after it was announced top clubs would play to empty stadiums.

The rest of Europe rapidly followed suit with Frankfurt and Madrid falling by 4%, Paris 3.9% and London 3.3%. Technology companies were hard hit by the sell-off. Airlines and cruise ship operators also slumped with American Airlines losing 8.5%, Carnival 9.4% and Royal Caribbean Cruises 9%.

Over the four days that followed markets continued to fall as the disease spread and by the time markets closed in New York that Friday evening, the rout had reached epic proportions with the Dow marking up its biggest points loss in history, bringing the week's losses to 12% and the end was nowhere in sight.

It was the worst fall since 2008 at the onset of the financial crisis.

‘If that isn’t a feekin black swan event, then I don’t feekin know what is,’ Pat mumbled to himself watching the Wall Street closing bell on Bloomberg television as he got his papers together for an early departure to Nice.

It was one of those events that marked a generation, like the 2001 attack on the World Trade Center in New York, or Lehmann Brothers in 2008, but in slow motion.

Suddenly Brexit wasn’t looking like such a good idea, thought Pat with a grim smile, as the consequences of the global economic impact hit the City of London with the disease spreading through the Middle East, to Iran, Iraq and Kuwait, raising fears the pandemic would be more severe than initially envisaged.

Already warnings were coming in from manufacturing as Jaguar Land Rover was forced to fly components out of China in suitcases as factory shutdowns brought assembly lines to a standstill.

CHAPTER 5

RELAXING IN THE VILLA CONTESSA'S more intimate family lounge, Pat was catching up with the evening news on the Irish TV channel RTÉ, the lead story was the return to Ireland of The Book of Lismore, an ancient Gaelic manuscript. It had been donated to University College Cork by the trustees of the Chatsworth Settlement.

The book, compiled for Fínghin Mac Carthaigh, the Lord of Carbery from 1478 to 1505, consisted of 198 large vellum folios containing some of medieval Irish literature's greatest masterpieces, including the lives of Irish saints, the only surviving Irish translation of the travels of Marco Polo, and the adventures of the hero Fionn mac Cumhaill, or Finn MacCool.

It had been taken in the siege of Kilbrittain Castle in Cork in the 1640s, and given to the Earl of Cork at Lismore Castle.

Hidden behind a walled up doorway in the 18th century together with the Lismore Crozier, an ancient wood and bronze shepherd's crook, a symbol of power in Ireland at that time, it was rediscovered during renovation work in 1814. Later it was transferred to Devonshire House in London and then Chatsworth, the seat of the Dukes of Devonshire, where it remained the property of the trustees of the Chatsworth Settlement.

As Pat watched the Taoiseach, Micheal Martin, welcome the return of ‘one of the great books of Ireland’, praising the generosity of Duke of Devonshire, he recalled the Wallace Codex, and the unexplained silence of Simmonds since their strange encounter in San Sebastian.

The Wallace Codex had been scientifically authenticated with an estimated value of twenty million dollars or more if put up to auction by Sotheby’s or Christie’s.

There was however the delicate question of ownership of the codex, which was now safely stored in the Geneva Freeport. Anna Basurko’s research had found no historical record of the codex, not the slightest trace, leaving a mystery surrounding its origin and historical ownership

That apart, there was Pat Kennedy’s agreement with Simmonds, whereby the lawyer was due half of the valuation, which meant in addition to the one million dollars paid into Cavendish Holdings, another nine million dollars were due to the skittish lawyer.

Pat called Anna who suggested a visit to Belize, which was out of the question, and not recommendable for Anna, starting with the problem of her safety. He had heard a lot about crime in that country and did not want her taking unnecessary risks running after a somewhat shady lawyer.

After reflection Pat looked at his watch, it was morning in Sao Paulo, Brazil. He picked up his phone and called Henrique da Souza. It was more than a year since Henrique had been

evacuated to the safety of Brazil by Kennedy following his dangerous run in with the pro-Beijing authorities in Hong Kong after his arrest during the demonstrations against the introduction of new laws.

Clashes between protesters and police had escalated dramatically with several injured, hundreds arrested—many charged with rioting, a crime that carried a severe prison sentence and guaranteed those involved would end up being marked as dissenters and trouble makers by the Mainland authorities, not a good thing for the future career of a promising young banker.

Pat had great plans for Henrique in Brazil and South America in general, however, the pandemic had momentarily complicated his project.

Henrique had multiple talents, he was young, an amateur of martial arts, and his experience as an active member of the democratic movement on the streets of Hong Kong had shown he could more than take care of himself in a difficult situation. Pat concluded that a visit to Belize and Central America would do him no harm and could add to Henrique's experience, a useful introduction to INI's business interests in the region.

The young banker had studied economics in London, and knew all that needed to be known about offshore banking and crookery, including that of certain Russians who were no strangers to Hong Kong and Macau.

Henrique was born into an old Portuguese family whose ancestors had arrived in Macau in the early 18th century when the city had been a Portuguese Colony—established on the west bank of the Pearl River, where it prospered for nearly 500 years before it was returned to China in 1999, two years after Hong Kong.

Many regretted the Portuguese were part of a dwindling community and of those registered in Macau only 10% could speak the language.

Henrique was a polyglot and like many Macanese he had grown up speaking Portuguese, English, Cantonese and Mandarin. Then over the course of his three year sojourn in Europe—during his studies in Lisbon and London, he had made many Spanish friends, thus adding another language to his multiple talents, an easy step from Portuguese.

On his return home from Europe, he joined INI—thanks to an introduction by an uncle, a senior lawyer at the bank in Hong Kong, where until his run in with the authorities he had been launched on a promising career.

CHAPTER 6

WHERE DID ALL THE MONEY COME FROM? Pat had asked himself. It wasn't as if he didn't know, which didn't prevent him from marveling at the result. Panama and places like it were the end recipients of a constant flow of money from every corner of the planet, that is anywhere where money could be made, or stolen.

What made that money different was that it had passed through, or around, the fiscal net of the respective states in which it was generated, by whatever means, escaping all forms of governmental control and taxation, often arriving in Panama by the most devious of routes.

Channeling money to offshore financial centres was an everyday part of INI's business, and that of other banks like it, 24 hours a day, 7 days a the week, year in and year out. Pat was amused by the idea that anyone with a modestly large bank account could escape what the Panamanians called the 'frivolities' of British or European governments, especially in matters of taxation. Investors, if that's what they could be called, could even obtain Panamanian citizenship, and those with substantially more money at their disposition, could, if they so wished, retire like legendary South American despots in the Central American republic.

When it came to money Pat was not immoral, he was simply amoral. Moral considerations simply did not exist in his universe, though it was wise to avoid the sanctions of the law, as he had already learnt. Beyond that it was as the Romans put it *pecunia non olet*.

Humanity needed banks, and he, Pat Kennedy, fulfilled that need.

He remembered one particular visit to Panama a few years earlier when he had met up with his then young protege, Lian Clancy, who had since gravitated to the very top of INI in the City of London.

Pat recalled arriving and disembarking at the VIP enclosure of Tocumen International Airport, and how, at the precisely the same moment, Liam Clancy had arrived at the Albrook Bus Terminal, nearer the centre of Panama City.

Liam, accompanied by a newly found girlfriend, Gisele, had spent about the same time to cover the distance from Bocas del Toro, about 300 kilometres to the west of Panama City, as Pat had spent to cover the 10,000 kilometres from London.

The young couple had been seated in the cramped back row of a bus, above the motor with the heat and noise that went with it. Luckily for them they were spared the odours of the toilet, an arm's length from Liam, it was locked, *Fuera de Servicio*, announced a scribbled note stuck on the door.

The next day Pat had risen early for a meeting with Jose Laborda, a corporate lawyer whose family's connection with the bank went back to the sixties, when the Fitzwilliams and Castlemain families owned the then small Irish bank. Laborda's father had been introduced to David Castlemain's father by a mutual friend, Malcolm Smeaton Snr.

During the fifty years that followed, the law firm had supplied legal, financial and consultancy services to the Irish bank and its Caribbean emanation.

Beside the usual legal advice relating to investments, contracts and real estate transactions, the firm provided more specialised services—for which there was an ever growing demand, mostly the creation of Panamanian and offshore companies for foreign businesses, or individuals, the setting up of private foundations, the opening of all types of offshore bank accounts, questions relating to the registration of trademarks, patents, copyrights, and last but not least immigration. The latter concerned the obtention of permits, or visas, for the entry and sojourn of foreigners in Panama, and procedures related to the acquisition of Panamanian citizenship.

Panama had enjoyed a privileged position in Central America for more than 100 years, the transoceanic canal was not only of national importance to Washington, but a vital point of passage for worldwide shipping. Then, in more recent times, Panama City had become an important hub for air travel between North and South America with in addition daily connections to Europe and Asia.

Laborda's law firm was one of the many such firms in Panama City, but smaller than the larger better known providers of legal and trust services such as Morgan and Morgan or Mossack Fonseca. It offered a more personalised service to its clients in a country where discretion was a way of life.

Panamanian providers of legal and trust services, together with their branches throughout the Caribbean, made it easy for their clients to set up offshore bank accounts, or shell companies, without public disclosure of ownership, or the identity of their directors, in any one of a number of tax havens including the British Virgin Islands, home to about forty percent of the world's offshore companies.

For more demanding clients, they proposed shadowy offshore islands such as Niue, a tiny South Pacific island nation with a population of fewer than 2,000 which offered registration for certain Chinese and Russian clients.

More recently Belize had got in on the act, especially since Panama Papers had leaked millions of documents from Mossac Fonseca's database, including a two billion dollar trail that led all the way to Vladimir Putin with his best friend—the cellist Sergei Roldugin, at the centre of a scheme in which money from Russian state banks was hidden offshore, part of which had ended up in a Russian ski resort where Vladimir Putin's daughter Katerina had married.

Some of the world's biggest financial institutions, including HSBC, City & Colonial, Société Générale, Credit Suisse, UBS,

and Commerzbank, had aided clients set up complex structures via Panama, to hide money from their respective country's tax collectors and government authorities. Nominee directors, that is stand-in directors, hid the identity of the real owners of bank accounts held by anonymous offshore companies, which together with the laws of secrecy in the different jurisdictions, made it hard if not impossible for authorities to track down tax dodgers and other persons of interest.

Amongst the many legal structures establish in Panama were foundations, initially listed as non-profit making organisations, declaring for example the World Wildlife Fund—an international ONG listed by Forbes as one of the world's leading charities, as their beneficiary, a detail that could be changed by the stroke of a pen and without the least formality.

Pat remembered having taken the precaution of walking to Laborda's office, situated in an office tower in Riu Plaza, off Avenida Cruz Herrera, a short, but sticky, ten minutes on foot from the Intercontinental. He had learnt one could never be too careful when it came to the bank's business in cities like Panama, a pole of attraction for sensation seeking media investigators.

Pat's business was discussed directly with Laborda in a business like manner. It was a serious, to the point of not wasting time on the normal niceties of international business.

CHAPTER 7

IT WAS THE BEGINNING OF JULY when John, Ekaterina and their two children arrived at Nice International Airport where they were picked up by the helicopter and flown to *Las Indias*. Then after leaving their baggage, to be ferried to the villa separately, they took the yacht's tender to the landing at Beaulieu where Pat was waiting.

Ekaterina looked surprised when she saw Pat.

'You're looking very well Pat!' she exclaimed. 'The Mediterranean climate is working wonders.'

Pat beamed, then after reflection, 'Was I looking that bad?'

'It's true Pat, you're looking great,' John exclaimed, stepping in to rescue Ekaterina from any embarrassment.

'I'll let you into the secret when we get back to the villa,' whispered Pat with a sly wink.

Their first priority was the two children, and whilst Ekaterina and Lili set about settling them in their rooms, Pat walked with John in the gardens to talk about his plans.

The idea that he could live to the age of 120 or 150 changed Pat's outlook on life, that is to say his own life. All risks were to be avoided, losing 10 years of life was a risk that every human ran. But losing 80 or more years was unacceptable.

‘Have you ever heard of the mole rat?’ asked Pat. ‘No? Well it lives in Africa, it’s a bare-skinned rodent. Rather ugly, lives underground.’

‘Okay Pat, what’s so special about your rat?’ said John humouring him.

‘My rat, unlike almost all other mammals, doesn’t become biologically old as time passes.’

‘I see, you’ve been talking to our friends at LifeGen again,’ said John with a knowing smile.

‘Listen John, this is serious. Did you know that for us humans, the risk of dying doubles every 8 years once you’ve passed 40.’

John didn’t need to be told that, and what’s more he didn’t need to be reminded. He was already on the verge of great age.

‘So tell me the news,’ Pat.

‘Those naked mole rats have no increase in the risk of death even when they are 25 times older than their age of puberty. In the case of humans, us, it doesn’t matter how old you are, your death is random.’

‘Look Pat, this is fucking depressing on a nice day like this,’ sighed John looking at the Mediterranean landscape beyond the gardens of the Villa Contessa.

‘Hang on, there’s some good news.’

John shot him a skeptical glance as the butler served them coffee.

‘Our rats live extremely long lives compared to other rats, over 30 years in captivity and up to 17 years in the wild. The rats we know ...’

‘You mean some of your clients,’ John interjected.

Pat ignored him.

‘Normal rats live about six years when the conditions are good. Now I’m not saying mole rats are immortal, they of course eventually die. Their half-life is about 19 years. That’s based on the observation of a colony of over 3,000 mole rats in a research facility over a period of more than 30 years.’

John looked out at the horizon as Pat droned on.

‘They found that on any given day,’ he persisted, ‘an average rat’s chances of dying were 1 in 10,000. Better still, the chances of a mole rat dying at one year of age or at 25 is the same. Which means for us humans we would have the same chance of dying each day whether we were 30 or 90,’ Pat announced triumphantly.

‘So where does this all get us?’

Pat stood up.

‘How do I look John.’

John scrutinised his friend.

‘Not bad considering.’

‘I mean do you see any difference.’

John grudgingly admitted he looked in good form, which he put down to Pat’s sojourn at the Villa Contessa.

‘Look at my skin, my hair, the grey streaks are almost gone.’

‘So tell me Pat have you been taking those vitamin pills or something?’

‘No, better than that ... you see my naked mole rats produce a protein called hyaluronan, which protect their genomes from damage and eliminate cellular mutations. This was used in Ancient Egypt and was extracted from a plant called *Senna alexandrina* to produce a molecule, the main ingredient of a medicine used by the Pharos.’

John shook his head.

‘LifeGen,’ Pat insisted, ‘has formulated a cure for aging from this and other molecules discovered in Mexico used by the Aztecs.’

John looked up at the blue sky. ‘Prolonging life, to what good? Don’t forget, we human beings are voracious predators,’ John reminded Pat. ‘A fact observed in every civilisation, past and present, in fact for as long as man and his ancestors have existed, and I don’t see anything positive in the kind of future we’re building.’

‘Perhaps we could change that John,’ said Pat softly.

The world had changed, the question was whether it was for the better or worse. Pat was already convinced it was not for the better. From his Gulfstream, flying 12 kilometres above the surface of the earth he had seen no borders, those that did lived in a fantasy world, if proof was needed they only had to look at humanity’s ills, the contagion provoked by a virus, the unstoppable flow of money and mass immigration.

‘In 1900, the average life expectancy for an American was 49 years. Now it’s approaching 80 years, and here in Beaulieu it’s over 90,’ Pat declared in an upbeat tone.

‘The past is a foreign country,’ John told his friend.

‘So is the future,’ retorted Pat.

‘You’re right there,’ John accorded him. ‘But what is the point in extending life on a dead planet, because that’s the way things are going, oceans awash with plastics, valleys flooded to build dams, roads slashed through primary forests for mining projects, and population growth spiraling out of control.

‘Perhaps the wisdom of the elders, those who had lived long lives and through many crises, could change that,’ said Pat. ‘People like you John.’

* * *

An hour later, once Will had been confided to Pat’s nanny, the women, together with Alena—who was now sixteen, joined Pat

and John waiting on the terrace where a table had been set for dinner and drinks were served under the watchful eye of Pat's butler.

'Anna and Padraig will arrive in a couple of days,' Pat informed them, 'this is a little dinner between us. Once everybody is here we'll discuss our plans for Egypt. In the meantime the children can enjoy the pool.'

Ekaterina and Alena admired the view, the Riviera had always had an almost mystical hold on Russians.

'So Pat,' Ekaterina asked impatiently, 'what's the mystery behind your sudden glowing tone.'

'Let's sit down first,' he proposed pointing to the dinner table, maintaining the suspense. He nodded to his butler who disappeared inside to supervise the diner service.

He told them the story of Galenus.

'Incredible,' whispered Ekaterina. 'And it really works?'

Lili raised her eyebrows.

'Yes, and I've ordered the same for John.'

There was a silence.

'Is it safe?' asked Ekaterina, looking at John, then Alena.

'Look at me, I've been taking it for nearly a month,' said Pat beaming.

He took a small transparent pill bottle from his pocket and opened it, shaking out two capsules. ‘One for me, and one for John.’

John after listening to the story of Pat’s rats hesitated, then picked it up, popped it into his mouth and swallowed it with a glass of water.

‘Great,’ said Pat.

‘Does it work on everybody? asked Anna.

‘We don’t know, but it works on mice.’

There was a collective gasp, then they burst out laughing.

‘Here’s to Galenus.’

‘You’ll make a fortune,’ said Ekaterina.

‘No,’ announced Pat firmly. ‘It’s for us.'

John wasn’t convinced, it reminded him of Aldous Huxley’s book, *The Doors of Perception*, which described the writer’s own experiences with mescaline, and discussed ladrenochrome—a compound with similar effects to the psychedelic cactus. Huxley described adrenochrome as ‘a product of the decomposition of adrenaline’, which in fact turned out to be correct.

John was anything but a fantasist, though after impulsively swallowing Pat’s capsule he had his doubts. As an academic he

knew only too well that history and literature were full of stories of youth and eternal life.

John wondered if he would have a mescaline experience like Huxley, expecting ‘visions of many-colored geometries, of animated architectures, rich with gems and fabulously lovely, of landscapes with heroic figures, of symbolic dramas trembling perpetually on the verge of the ultimate revelation,’ but nothing happened, ‘no landscapes, no enormous spaces, no magical growth and metamorphosis of buildings’.

It was a pity he thought. On the other hand he respected Rob as a medical scientist, and if Rob said Galenus was harmless, then he had nothing to lose in humouring Pat, which did not prevent him from harbouring the idea that perhaps what he said might be true.

John remembered his younger days in Sri Lanka, he recalled drugs and drencrom in *A Clockwork Orang*e, an ingredient in Moloko Plus—which ‘would sharpen you up and make you ready for a bit of the old ultra-violence,’ or in *Loathing in Las Vegas*—when Raoul Duke and Dr. Gonzo sped across the Nevada Desert. Duke under the influence of mescaline.

In the meantime he’d gotten older, a lot older, and against all expectations he—a confirmed bachelor, had married and was the father of a son who could have been mistaken for his grandson or even great grandson.

He silently concluded that if it worked, if he could live longer, and in good health, it would be good for Ekaterina, Alena his stepdaughter, and his son Will.

As Pat described Galenus, John thought about Huxley's mescaline—a psychedelic drug extracted from the small peyote cactus, *Anhalonium Lewinii*, had been used for thousands of years in Mexico, where it was called mescal, used in religious ceremonies, said to contain remarkable physiological properties and sacred to the Indians.

* * *

Pat and John wandered through the yacht show, Pat hiding behind his dark glasses, casually dressed—the last thing he wanted was to be recognised. John was of less interest to paparazzi, he kept a low profile, leaving the bling to Ekaterina and her friends from the art world.

Champagne receptions overflowed from the tents as they made their way past Ferraris and Aston Martins for sale on the quayside, looking for the tender to take them out to *Las Indias* now anchored offshore in the Bay of Monaco, making an appearance for the event—the showcase for superyachts, and a chance for certain owners to parade their vessel.

Unlike some yacht owners who sent their helicopter on some frivolous errand or to stock up at the local farmers markets, Pat avoided upsetting his ecologist minded friends and guests like Kyril Kyristoforos, though in remote locations, like in the

Amazon or Colombia, helicopters and seaplanes were a necessity.

They had driven up to the show from Beaulieu to join the crowd of visitors, most from the top end of the boating world. Pat wasn't, however, a dyed in the wool sailor, he didn't even especially like the sea, but he did enjoy the comforts of his yacht that could take him almost anywhere in the world bordered by a sea or accessible by a broad and deep river. Of course it was much slower than his Gulfstream, it was different, it was like a home he could take with him, along with his family and friends.

The number of superyachts had grown at an astonishing rate, to the point shipbuilders couldn't keep up with the demand. It was no wonder that harbours like Port Hercule in Monte Carlo, especially during the Monaco Yacht Show, seemed like a supermarket carpark, though packed with yachts, the difference apart from being boats was together they were worth a billion dollars or more.

The market for billionaires' status symbols and toys had become a real growth sector. Even with the onset of the pandemic tens of thousands were employed as crew members and shipyards overflowed with orders.

Las Indias was not the biggest at the show, that prize went to *Kismet*, owned by Shahid Khan, measuring 96 metres from bow to stern, which was dwarfed by the *Azzam*, not present, with its

180 metres, owned by Sheikh Khalifa bin Zayed Al-Nahyan, President of the United Arab Emirates.

They searched the quayside for the tender sent from *Las Indias*, lost amongst the comings and goings of a multitude of small boats in the harbour, ferrying people and supplies to and from the bigger yachts anchored offshore.

Like *Las Indias*, most, if not all, the yachts were owned by opaque offshore companies registered in Panama or the British Virgin Islands with their day-to-day operations run by management companies.

Anchored not far from *Las Indias* was Sir Philip Green's *Lionheart*, which Pat studiously avoided contact, rumour had it the British billionaire was in serious financial trouble.

Yachts like *Las Indias* had a crew of two dozen or more, including personal trainers, masseuses and hairdressers. For the coming cruise to Egypt, in addition to George Pyke's security team, there was also the nanny for the smaller children and a governess to take care of the older ones during cruise, which would coincide with the children's school holidays.

CHAPTER 8

DURING HIS VISIT TO BELIZE a year earlier year, when returning from a visit to an archaeological site in nearby Guatemala, Pat's convoy had stopped at a filling station, a technical stop, that is a pee. Once he'd relieved himself he'd wandered over to the bar, as usual was curious to see how the others lived.

Suddenly, his friend and head of security, George Pyke, appeared, holding his Glock, bundling Pat back to the vehicle, slamming the door shut. Pat didn't have time to be bewildered or afraid. His friends didn't hang around either, they too piled into their vehicles. Pat's driver slammed the SUV into gear and stamped on the gas, laying a trail of burning rubber on the forecourt as he slalomed out of the filling station in a haze of blue smoke.

George had pushed Pat to the floor. Then peering out the back window he slide his Glock back into its holster and announced the danger was past.

The driver quickly explained how as he was paying for a can of Coke two armed men had appeared, it was a hold-up, a relatively common event in Belize.

It had taken Pat and his friends just a few moments to realize they were in a lawless country, which hadn't overly alarmed

him. Pat, as usual remained cool, it wasn't the first time he had been confronted by gun toting South American *desperados*.

That had been in the good times, when the economy was booming, when tourist arrivals had reached record levels.

It was the same all along the Maya Riviera, Cancun, Playa del Carmen, Tulum and San Pedro in Belize overflowed—rave parties, cocaine, alcohol, sex, money, violence, murder and gang wars.

In a few shorts weeks the tourists disappeared, then *nada*, nothing, and another sort of crime appeared, the kind linked to poverty and desperation as development projects stalled, construction sites shut down, workers returned to their homes in distant regions of Mexico, Guatemala and Central America and business ground to a halt.

A year earlier the holdup seemed like a sign to Pat, Belize was a place where many bankers feared to tread, but with much potential. During his short visit to Belize City, he couldn't help remarking an unusual number of shiny brass nameplates marking law firms and plaques announcing the consulates of distant countries that included Malaysia and Taiwan as well as the usual honorary consuls in such countries.

Belize was a 'low-tax jurisdiction', that is to say a tax haven, and in the purest sense of the term, providing the incorporation of offshore companies, locally denominated International Business Companies, within a few hours. These IBCs did not pay taxes on earnings from abroad, but were excluded from

doing business in Belize. However, they had the advantage that they could receive offshore income such as dividends, capital gains, earned interest and revenues, which paid by IBCs incorporated in Belize to non-citizens were tax-free and required no reporting.

In the early 1990s, not long after full independence, following the example of many other former British territories, including the Bahamas, Jamaica, Barbados, British Virgin Islands, Cayman Islands, Guyana, Suriname, and Trinidad and Tobago, the government of Belize enacted legislation that allowed it to become a tax haven, creating the kind of environment that would attract offshore companies.

In addition, Belize International Trusts included a permanent exemption from personal and business taxes on earnings generated by assets in a trust. Estates also received comprehensive exemptions from taxes related to inheritance, succession and gifting.

One of the major provisions in the Offshore Banking Act was it allowed financial institutions with a minimum of 25 million dollars in capital to apply for an unrestricted license for banking operations without local regulation.

As restrictions were progressively imposed on traditional tax havens such as Switzerland and Luxembourg, Belize offered secrecy to companies, foundations and trusts incorporated in the country, guaranteed by banking regulations that mandated names and account information be disclosed only after proof

that crimes had been committed was submitted to a local court of justice which if satisfied issued an appropriate order.

The absence of exchange controls offered offshore businesses incorporated in the country the possibility of transferring unlimited amounts of currency without reporting requirements with the advantage Belize had no tax treaties with other governments.

More surprising was the fact that Belize was included in the fair taxation category of jurisdictions by the EU Council, whitelisted for improving its tax regime to the benefit of entrepreneurs and cross-border investments.

That did not stop Belize from being a crossroad for drug trafficking, with its vast isolated regions and few if any roads, where clandestine airstrips allowed narco-traffickers to fly in and refuel, where the means to monitor the movement of private aircraft at night was close to zero.

Pat Kennedy's rise to riches had been punctuated by a series of crises and each of which had proven beneficial to his personal fortunes, opportunities, moments when risks paid off, whilst the weak of heart curled up and waited for the bad times to pass.

The moment was ripe in Belize, then and now, for Pat to set up a local operation through one of INI's many subsidiaries, and why not via Malcolm Smeatons' Anglo-Dutch Commonwealth Bank—a suitably opaque screen for his plans

in Colombia, in the Cordillera Oriental, an eerie high above the world.

Once the crisis passed things would be different and rich new Americans, not only those to the north of the Rio Grande, but also *los nuevos ricos* from Latin America, would converge in their brash new playground, a new Eldorado—The Maya Riviera.

CHAPTER 9

ANNA BASURKO'S EXPEDITION to salvage the *Espiritu Santo* off the coast of Colombia had been concluded with the opening of an exhibition of the treasures at Cartagena's Historical Museum. The museum, a magnificent restored colonial style palace, was situated on Plaza de Bolivar. It dated from 1770, and faced the large plaza and its palm studded gardens, flanked on one side by the Catedral de Santa Catalina, and appropriately, at least on this occasion, opposite the Museo del Oro.

The Historical Museum was protected by an impressive cohort of armed soldiers, police and security personnel who filtered the guests arriving for the press conference on the second floor of the palace.

It was a big event with the presence of Ivan Duque Marquez, Colombia's then recently elected president, accompanied by his minister of culture, the president of the Colombian Institute of Anthropology and History, naval admirals, and naturally the mayor of Cartagena de Indias.

The media was there in force, national television, CNN, the New York Times, the list was long. The star of the show was the *Espiritu Santo* and a temporary exhibition of its treasures: gold and silver bars, Spanish reales, richly decorated gold chains and crosses, jewellery and ornaments. President

Marquez spoke of a great national treasure and introduced Don Pedro Heridia, Sir Patrick Kennedy, Scott Fitznorman, Robert Guiglion, and the expedition's team to the press.

Then turning to Anna, Marques poured praise on her, telling the world without Anna Basurko's efforts the *Espiritu Santo* and its treasure would have never been known let alone discovered.

The attention of the media was immediately focused on this attractive young woman, beautifully, though soberly dressed for the occasion. The image of the marine archaeologist excited the press almost as much as the gold that sparkled behind the brightly light armoured glass display cases.

The images were flashed across the planet and the members of the expedition became instant 24 hour media celebrities. It was a huge boost for Colombia and more especially Cartagena. Pat Kennedy took advantage of the situation to announce investment plans in the country together with his good friend Don Pedro Heridia, including a new museum to be built in the Getsemani area of the city between the smart residential districts and the Casco Antiguo.

The total haul included 940kg of gold bullion carried in 28 chests, 32,400 gold doubloons, gold chains and crosses, 2,100,000 pieces of eight, 2,000kg of silver bars, a chest of emeralds, 3 chests of various other precious stones, and multiple objects in gold, silver, precious stones and works of art.

Fixing a value would required long work by numismatists specialised in rare coins—the value of which could exceed many times the spot price of the gold they contain with certain worth tens and even hundreds of thousands of dollars. Then there were the precious stones that would required the knowledge of gemologists to estimate their value.

All that without taking into account the fine works of art recovered, which led the specialists to estimate the total value of the treasure at nearly four billion dollars, shared between the Colombian government and their partners.

Kennedy and his friends were two billion dollars richer, thanks to the treasures stolen from the peoples of New World by the Conquistadors, peoples to whom little thought was spared.

When asked about his future plans Pat Kennedy smiled and vaguely hinted at a second field campaign to conclude the archaeological work on the *Espiritu Santo*, the site of which was protected by the Colombian Navy, and his interest in an archaeological field work somewhere in Central America.

* * *

Pat Kennedy's banking empire was built around a number of quasi-autonomous units linked by a complex structure of cross holdings which he was in the process of extending into Latin America with banks in Panama, Colombia and Brazil controlled by a Dublin holding.

Pat's hard won experience had taught him how to develop a system that would protect the bank from unpredictable political events, such as Brexit, or the decisions of authoritarian governments in Moscow and Beijing. It was a system that had won him respect in a world where he had the power to transfer billions in a few strokes of a keyboard.

He lived in a world where wealth was power—what was the use of military might when the spoils of war were nothing but a devastated landscape of smoking rubble that offered a desolate shelter to the desperate hungry and ruined survivors?

CHAPTER 10

ALMOST A YEAR EARLIER, Henrique had peered down from the Cathay Pacific 777 as he commenced his voyage into exile. As the huge jet climbed, and banked into a broad westward turn over the Pearl River, his heart was heavy, filled with sadness.

Shaken by the speed of the events of the previous days, he realised it was possibly the last time he would see his home, the two cities where he had grown up and gone to school, the cities where those dear to him lived and worked, now fading into the dark night sky.

Hong Kong and Macau were South China's iconic cities, hives of buzzing activity and energy with their skyscrapers, streets filled with the lights of night markets and traffic, harbours filled with the glow of boats and restaurants, with the constant coming and going of ferries crisscrossing the waters of Guangzhou's Greater Bay Area, a megapolis with a population of fifteen or more million.

It had not been in his plans to leave his family, his girlfriend and his job. But like other activists fighting for democracy and freedom, he knew whether he stayed or not, he was now a marked man, the target of the authorities loyal to the Communist Party leaders in Beijing, under the sweeping new security laws designed to gag the millions of Hongkongers who

refused the authoritarian derive, one that had little respect for human and civil rights.

It was a sombre moment for Hong Kong as Beijing ditched the treaty, signed in 1997 with Great Britain—One Country, Two Systems, which guaranteed a transition period of 50 years, cast to the wind like a scrap of worthless paper.

Hong Kong's Beijing-appointed Chief Executive, Carrie Lam, had the power to decide which persons and what actions violated national security.

The new Office for Safeguarding National Security of the Central People's Government in the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region, now targeted all those suspected of foreign collusion, with the same system used by Beijing to silence dissidents, a warning to those who challenged the authority of Beijing. With sweeping powers and the threat of secret police, trial without juries, extradition to China and life imprisonment for those who refused to remain silent.

Under Xi Jinping China had become less tolerant, more oppressive, as conditions progressively deteriorated with clampdowns on freedom of speech and authoritarian rule extended to Hong Kong, whose citizens could face trial in China, where the legal system was designed to serve the sole interests of the Communist one party system.

An oppressive system that did not hesitate to hire agent provocateurs to attack demonstrators, allow police to beat citizens, target bystanders and children with pepper spray, shoot

journalists at close range with rubber bullets and throw protesters in jail.

To Henrique, Hong Kong and Macau's ways of life were being extinguished as businesses and banks were forced to abandon their values and fall in line with Beijing's dictate.

CHAPTER 11

‘LET ME START WITH CHAPARRAL TEA,’ announced Michel, ‘this is made from the creosote plant, *Larrea tridentata*, a smallish evergreen desert shrub, which according to Luis, are found in southern areas of the United States and northern regions of Mexico.’

He paused and looked at Luis Gutierrez, who nodded his approval.

‘As a dried herb, it seems this has been traditionally used by Amerindian peoples, including the Aztecs, to treat a whole range of medical conditions, though until now there’s not much research to support those claims. However, today researchers are discovering more medicinal uses and new ethnobotanical applications.’

He clicked on the keyboard of his laptop and a new image appeared on the screen.

‘What you see here is the creosote bush, the leaves and stems of which contain nordihydroguaiaretic acid, NDGA for short, a phenolic lignan, a potent antioxidant. In addition its resin contains a large quantity of essential oils as well as saponins, sapogenins, tannins, sterols, monoterpenes, and sesquiterpenes.’

He paused to ensure they were all following and for a little dramatic effect.

‘Now what interests us are the linear lignans—dibenzylbutanes, NDGA derivatives, these make up 50% of the resin covering the surface of the plants leaves. To give you an idea, from 5 to 10 grammes of NDGA can be extracted from 100 grammes of dry leaves, which incidentally is very interesting from a purely commercial point of view.

‘The reason being is that NDGA forms an important metabolite and powerful antioxidant, which is active against neurodegenerative disorders, senescence and aging symptoms, including premature ageing of human brain cells.

‘This is one of the components of the cocktail we have developed, though it is not the key element, that I will come to later.’

CHAPTER 12

HOW DID THE ANCIENTS SEE AGEING? That was a question Pat asked himself.

Some replied it was part of life, but what is life? Religions, philosophers and scientists had in turn provided their explanations to that question, one as old as humanity.

In the 21st century NASA proposed its own definition: life is a self-sustaining chemical system capable of Darwinian evolution.

‘That’s very nice,’ Pat told John, ‘but what interests us is human life, life on this planet.’

He was right, life on the planet Earth was made up of cells built from proteins and encoded as genes in DNA.

‘The rest doesn’t concern us,’ said John, ‘unless aliens suddenly turn up.’

John described the Gaia hypothesis, proposed by James Lovelock, which suggested the entire planet was a living entity, where biological life, animal or vegetable, supported by its oceans and landmasses, was a survival mechanism functioning on knowledge and experience accumulated over hundreds of millions of years, stored in the DNA of all living things, confronting change and adapting according to principals,

Darwinian or otherwise, which guaranteed the Earth's holistic continuity, as for AI that was a logical extension of the planet's toolbox.

Many in the Ancient World saw old age as a disease, John told him. However, the ancient Greek physician Galen thought otherwise. His treatise *Hygien*e, also known as *De sanitate tuenda*, written around AD175, was the only surviving classical study of gerontology, in which Galen considered ageing as a natural process that could be mitigated or even delayed through preventive measures such as diet.

Hippocrates wrote in the 5th century BC that a good doctor should travel and Galen took him at his word. When his father died he set off to Smyrna, Corinth and Alexandria in Egypt, where he studied the work of his famous predecessors, Hippocrates, Herophilus and the learned doctors of his own times.

Today, nearly two millennia after his vast work was written, its similarity to present day ideas is remarkable, both on care of the elderly and on models of ageing.

'So you see, Galen thought of ageing holistically, as a lifelong process with a number of stages,' John explained to his friend.

Galen divided life into its first seven years, maturity and old age proper. He recognized that a person's ageing 'path' was highly individual, with a wide range of possible health outcomes at each stage. And he also realised the importance of a healthy youth as the basis for a robust old age.

He wrote his work at the peak of his career, at the time he was the physician of the Roman emperor Marcus Aurelius, after establishing his reputation in Alexandria.

Galen like many physicians of his day based his ideas on medical theories common at that time, these included the concept of humours—based on bodily fluids such as blood—and the curative properties of 'divinely' inspired dreams. But he also pioneered the empirical study of human functions and diseases and was reputed for his remedies based on herbs and spices, which won the approval of fellow doctors.

In ancient times when religious taboo forbade dissection of corpses, Galen found ingenious ways to investigate anatomy. He studied skeletons exposed in flooded cemeteries, and in the course of treating the wounds of gladiators, whose muscles and blood vessels were exposed to view. In addition he conducted anatomical demonstrations on animals, including public vivisection of live Barbary macaques to demonstrate the function of nerves.

Galen represented a break with with earlier thinkers on lifespan and ageing. In the 6th century BC, Athenian statesman Solon saw old age as the inevitable and final stage of life—one of ten, and each of seven years. Galen on the other hand divided the final stage of old age into three phases of unspecified length, from active old age to senility, arguing that the 'causes of destruction' were present 'innately from the beginning'.

He saw care of the elderly as integral to the work of physician, and believed it should emphasize prevention. He also noted that many of the ills of ageing, such as dizziness, eye inflammation and ear pain, could be palliated or even delayed to improve the quality of life in old age.

Galen's recommendations are still valid today—walking and moderate running, a simple diet of gruel, raw honey, vegetables and fowl.

Death, he stressed, was inevitable as the body underwent a programmed deterioration. But, life could be prolonged. At a time when many died long before the age of 70, he spoke of his contemporaries, Antiochus, a doctor still practicing in his eighties, and the grammarian Telephus, who lived to nearly 100 with his faculties intact. Galen noted that their achievement exemplified the success of principles laid out in *Hygiene*, which he believed had contributed to his own longevity.

'So you see Pat, Galen's holistic approach to *gerokomica* is still the path to optimizing the health and long life, which means we shouldn't abuse our new found youth.'

CHAPTER 13

BACK IN LONDON PAT WALLOWED in the pleasure of his new found form which came with a strange absence of enthusiasm about getting back into the business melee he was used to. It was not a lack of interest, but a sudden distancing, an abstraction, as though what was happening in London or Hong Kong did not concern him.

He had handed the reins of INI in London and Hong Kong to Liam Clancy and Angus MacPherson respectively, whilst his own role became largely symbolic.

Relaxing at home with his friend John Francis, they followed the drama at 10 Downing Street with a mixture of amusement and horror, watching the antics of Boris Johnson and his cohorts acting out their parts in what seemed like a Netflix drama.

Entertaining except for the real life tragedy it caused millions, hit by the pandemic and its economic fallout, compounded by the seemingly never-ending Brexit farce that was at long last approaching its denouement.

The latest episode announced the entry of Lady Macbeth on the scene, played by Carrie Symonds, as Bojo looked at the skull of Yorrick—that of Domminic Cummings, ‘Alas, poor Dom! I knew him, a fellow of infinite jest, of most excellent fancy’.

The economic model of the consumer society was being tested to destruction after a 20% fall in UK national output in the first wave of the pandemic, as hundreds of thousands of people lost their jobs and millions more were threatened as the second wave unfurled and businesses went to the wall.

At the same time the government, like businesses, accumulated unsustainable debts, overshadowed by the grim threat of a no-deal Brexit as the construction of vast truck parks continued at British ports, in anticipation of chaos predicted on January 1, 2021, when trucking firms and exporters would pay a heavy price for politicians' futile stupidity in exiting the EU, in exchange for what—the pipe dream of sovereignty?

What was new in this particular pandemic was that governments had themselves brought about an economic collapse by deliberate acts of policy. Nothing had prepared the world for such a scenario—a recession of the like not seen in 300 years.

The problem lay in the fact that Neoliberalism had hollowed out the capacity of public sectors, under-funding what it had not privatised.

Downing Street had become the battlefield in a power struggle between the prime minister's partner, the mother of his fifth child, and his Rasputin—Dominic Cummings, who fought for the ear of the king—Boris Johnson.

Two camps fought it out, on the one side Cummings, the Brexit champion and his sinister henchmen, and on the other

Lady Macbeth, in the form of Carrie Symonds and her court followers.

Finally, Cummings, who resembled another infamous Shakespearian character, Richard III, with his furtive eyes and sour demeanour, not to speak of his unconventional preference for slobish hoodies, lost the vicious battle, prompting Cain's resignation, and his own hot on his sidekick's heels.

The victor, Symonds, emerged as an unforeseen force to be reckoned at Number10.

'We're in the middle of a feeking pandemic,' Pat marvelled, 'people are worried about their health, their jobs and families, and these wee feekers are squabbling over the privilege of bending Johnson's ear.'

'It's fucking scandal,' concurred John Francis, 'just as as deaths have reached 50,000.'

CHAPTER 14

AN HOUR LATER JOHN FRANCIS strolled easily down Buckingham Palace Road in the direction of Victoria Station before turning left up Eccleston Street where he was meeting Ekaterina at a place called Chucs.

It was a very upmarket district, one which he liked, where many homes were owned by offshore companies, as in the rest of Westminster where there were an estimated 10,000 such properties, right on the government's doorstep, and a further 6,000 in Kensington and Chelsea—where he lived in a splendid home, a few steps from Pat Kennedy's equally impressive pad.

John had walked the two miles from his place on Royal Hospital Road, and that morning the last thing in his mind was who owned what. He felt a spring in his step as he enjoyed the warm summer weather, looking forward to lunch with Anna and their two children in the small stylish restaurant.

The truth was since he had returned from Beaulieu he had never felt so good. Pat's pills were working miracles, though there was a slight but lingering doubt he had signed up on some Faustian pact.

In the meantime they had their cruise on Pat's yacht to think about, at the end of the month they would set off from Beaulieu, first stop Egypt.

Chucs was almost designed for the occasion, like a yacht, with its wood paneling, brass rails and vintage prints of Amalfi and the Cinque Terre.

Anna and the children arrived five minutes after John, the driver dropping them off outside the restaurant, Alena now a graceful teen, already excited at the approach of the holidays.

CHAPTER 15

AS PAT DROVE INTO INI'S HEADQUARTERS in the City, the gleaming crystal towers had a lifeless air, a morosity had descended on London's financial district which not more than a few months earlier had swarmed with workers, hurrying like bees or ants, dressed to kill, carrying their Starbucks coffees, clutching their smartphones as they walked with a swagger through the huge glass doors, their laptops on bandoliers casually slung over their shoulders.

Now the City had been transformed into a ghost town. The streets almost deserted. Traffic down to a trickle.

The second lockdown was transforming work and society, the pandemic had switched business into fast forward mode.

Was it the end of an era, the end of the office tower? The City of London had a pestilential air. Property was a no-go investment and major developers clocked up huge losses.

What with three million square metres of speculative offices in the pipeline, the sector would be a bloodbath for investors. The latest addition to the City skyline was 22 Bishopsgate, situated in the very heart of the Square Mile, a gargantuan office building, dwarfing all around it, more than twice the size of the Could Tower, only recently inaugurated.

What did this mean for INI, which, like other banks and financial institutions, had heavily invested in the City, Hong Kong and Moscow?

Pat himself was proof that the office was obsolete, his work place was more often than not his jet, or his yacht, a hotel suite or one of his homes, admittedly more comfortably than that of the vast majority of teleworkers. Internet had liberated millions, with the proportion of Europeans teleworkers shooting up from 5% to 40% on the other hand it had destroyed the livelihood of millions of others, small shopkeepers, chain stores and commercial centres, transforming tech giants into Leviathans.

Not only were goods delivered to homes, but meals too. A few clicks on the keyboard and you had what you wanted, if you had a job.

But owners of the local shops, pubs, restaurants, fast-food outlets, theatres, cinemas and sport clubs, asked what the future held for them.

Would city dwellers flee their homes, head for the hills, the coast and rural bliss? No one could say. In the meantime bankers and investors were counting their losses.

Whilst locked down citizens looked on aghast, politicians ran around like Mad Hatters with the government divided into two camps, fighting a life or death battle, each led by an unelected adviser, Carrie Simmons on one side and Dominic Cummings on the other.

The situation was echoed across the world, politicians stumbling around in the dark with no solution in view. The economic and social cost promised to be enormous, the coup de grâce to the Western World.

CHAPTER 16

‘YOU SEE SIR PATRICK,’ the minister of culture told his guest, ‘most of our visitors to Egypt are from Europe or China, but the really big spenders come from the Gulf, tourists who stay longer and bring more money and speak Arabic, unlike Europeans, not to talk of the Chinese who culturally unfamiliar are fearful and quickly in and out.’

The trip to Egypt had been organised for Pat, an important patron, who had contributed to research various programmes at the Faculty of Archaeology at the Cairo University, with a special pre-opening visit to the The Grand Egyptian Museum in Giza, one of the largest the largest archaeological museums in the world, originally scheduled to open in the first quarter of 2020, now put back to 2021.

Perhaps it was not a good time of the year to visit, too hot, but with the right transport and organisation that was a minor problem.

It was important to show the pandemic could be overcome and tourism, vital to Egypt’s economy could resume. The industry had been affected in more ways than could be imagined and especially Egypt with its tourist sector built around its extraordinary history and antiquities.

A year earlier, Pat Kennedy, en route from Hong Kong to London had stopped over in Egypt to visit the Grand Egyptian

Museum, scheduled to open in 2020, in the company of his archaeologist friend Ken Hisakawa.

The one billion dollar museum, designed by the Dublin-based Heneghan Peng Architects, planned to display the 5,400 treasures from the tomb of King Tutankhamen, along with 50,000 other objects from the old museum in downtown Cairo. Its official inauguration was planned for 2022, the centenary of Howard Carter's discovery of Tutankhamen's tomb.

The vast museum was situated at Giza so that visitors could contemplate the marvels of Egypt together after arriving at the new airport just 30 minutes from the site. Visitors would commence with a chronological tour starting from prehistory to the Greco-Roman period, with a presentation of recent discoveries plus monumental pieces too large to be housed in the old museum at Tahrir Square.

It would also present objects used in the daily life of the pharaohs, immersing visitors in the royal court, and not only how they dressed and what they ate, but also the embalming and funeral in preparation for the afterlife.

The object of that visit, in addition to the museum, had been to learn more about space archaeology and satellites imagery, which had been used in Egypt to uncover ancient ruins, and how it could be employed in Central and South America.

Ken had been following the work developed by Sarah Parcak, an Egyptologist, who was based in Alabama in the US. Using satellite imagery and other remote sensing tools, including

hyperspectral camera data, she had identified a huge number of undiscovered sites belonging to hitherto unknown Egyptian cultures.

He saw it as a way to accelerate his work in Central and South America and had persuaded Pat, without too much difficulty, to fly to Egypt to meet Parcak.

The Egyptologist had identified countless ancient settlements, many pyramids, and more than one thousand undiscovered tombs, including Tanis, the Lost City, excavated in 1939 by the French archaeologist Pierre Montet, who unearthed a royal tomb complex containing three intact and undisturbed burial chambers containing silver coffins, sarcophagi, golden masks and jewellery including bracelets, necklaces, pendants, tableware and amulets.

It was a completely new field compared to the traditional dig, carried out by archaeologists on their knees, scrapping away at the dirt with a trowel and brush in their hands.

* * *

That summer, as Pat and his friends prepared to embark for their Mediterranean cruise to Egypt, the Arab world was facing an unprecedented crisis caused by the pandemic that was ravaging oil consuming nations, where the pumps had stopped pumping. The severity of the crisis was underlined by the Saudi finance minister, who declared, ‘We are facing a crisis the world has never seen the likes of in modern history.’

Saudi Arabia, like the rest of the Arab world, was caught one way or another in the trap of oil dependency.

The centre of the Arab world had long since shifted from Cairo, Damascus and Baghdad, the centuries old capitals of Arab culture and wealth, eclipsed by the gleaming cities of the Gulf states. The old soul of the Arab world had declined into poverty as a result of twin evils, explosive population growth and war.

In 2015, Egypt's defence minister had mocked the Gulf's wealth when he told his adviser to ask Saudi Arabia for ten billion dollars in aid. His aide laughed at the idea. 'So what?' retorted the minister mockingly, 'They have money like rice.'

That minister is now Egypt's leader Abdel Fattah El Sisi.

The Gulf states owed their rise, wealth and influence to the serendipitous discovery of oil and gas in their sun scorched lands, which for centuries had been fly bitten backwaters, existing thanks to Mecca and its pilgrims, and the bases established by the British Empire to protect the sea routes to its distant outposts.

The pandemic would have long term consequences for the world economy, starting with oil and the end of a golden age for the petrodollar kingdoms on the southern shores of the Persian Gulf. The collapse of oil prices meant that many producing countries, which had counted on rising prices to finance their extravagant living styles, would see their budgets cut dramatically.

Even a country like Saudi Arabia, where the cost of extracting oil from ground was barely a handful of dollars, with its vast cash reserves, would feel the pain as its population exploded, unless it undertook a prodigious programme of economic development. Saudi Arabia, like its neighbours, imported almost all of its needs, with a population of 33 million, which had increased tenfold since 1950, made up off nearly 40% non-native residents—few of whom had any intention of ever returning to their homelands, would be impacted by a steep fall in government revenues of which almost 70% were generated from oil.

Algeria needed a price of 157 dollars a barrel to balance its budget while Oman needed 87 dollars. The response was to slash government budgets and the salaries of government employees.

In the medium term there was little hope oil prices would rise and not only the Arab world would be hit, Russian oil firms would also have to contended with falling revenues as would the Kremlin. The US had already seen its shale oil sector collapse, victim of the decision by Saudi Arabia to dominate the market and the subsequent price war with Russia.

Certain Arab leaders had foreseen the fall in prices, but had been caught short when the pandemic brought the date forward ten years, causing revenues to fall by 50% overnight, forcing the richer countries to eat into their cash reserves and the less well-off to borrow and raise taxes.

The knock on effect would hit countries like the Lebanon that had relied on big spending tourists from their oil rich Middle Eastern neighbours and the remittances of their own immigrant workers in places like Dubai.

Egypt with its population of more than one hundred million was caught in a trap of its own making—its lack of foresight whilst the Magregh was a victim of its incapacity to reform its political systems.

CHAPTER 17

OVER THE COURSE OF JOHN'S ALREADY RICH and long lifetime the world had been transformed, once made up of distant lands that most people never dreamed they would visit, it was now open to all. Modern travel had made even the furthest corners of the earth accessible to the citizens of developed countries and the middle classes of India, China and South America, whilst immigration brought millions of poor workers from the Third World to the First World.

However, whilst those voyagers lived on the same planet, they and their countries did not share the same values, though the did share the same aspirations to security and well-being, and all that modern technology could offer.

In the days when John was a boy, growing up in a very privileged Irish family, half the world's population had no access to education as we know it today, their womenfolk were illiterate, most worked the land as peasants and in countries often ruled by colonial powers. Today the sons and daughters of those people have access to basic education, five billion people use mobile phones, the majority living in cities or towns, where the poorest suffer from the evils of urban poverty, living in slums and favelas,

All that was the result of five centuries of globalisation, a process that began when Magellan's ships completed the first

circumnavigation of the globe and European powers colonised the Americas, Australasia and Africa.

The Industrial Revolution accelerated that process when the telegraph and trans-oceanic cables opened the world to markets in the City of London and speculation on raw materials and crops. By the middle of the 20th century globalisation and consumption had become irreversible, they were the drivers of banking and corporate expansion, the spread of education and knowledge with the desire of consumers and would-be consumers to live their version of the American Dream.

The world counted 2.5 billion people in 1950, in well under a century it had grown to 7.8 billion, and by the time that century was complete it would pass 10 billion.

Some said it was not numbers that were destroying the planet, but consumption. Pat knew it was both, he had seen the teeming millions of Asia, Africa, the destruction of the Amazon, and in his life the population of Europe had almost doubled.

Flying high above the Earth in his Gulfstream he had often marveled at the blaze of light that illuminated the night sky, at the same time realising that most of that energy came from fossil fuels. From his yacht he had sailed the oceans drowning in plastic, he had seen the pollution of Delhi, the squalor of Cairo, the misery of Mombasa and Manila.

He was not alone, many of the one billion passengers who took to the sky in the summer of 2019 could have seen what he

saw and asked the same questions if they had cared to look down at the earth on which they lived.

From his glass tower in Hong Kong he had observed the furious pace of development in China, the rise of authoritarian rule, the failure of the West to take up the challenge.

Lili's family had told him of the rise of Shenzhen, from a village of a few thousand to a city of 11 million in a few decades. Of Wuhan, a city the whole world now knew, which in 1968 had counted a population of two million, now transformed into a megapolis like Shenzhen, but dwarfed by Chongqing with its 30 million citizens.

China had succeeded where the Soviet Union had failed, and though it had created an enviable model of authoritarian capitalism, which many dreamed of emulating, it had had also created an unenviable environment for hundreds of millions of its citizens.

The writing was on the wall, visible to all but the blind.

Some chose the solar system, like Elon Musk—who planned to colonise Mars with his Starship. Pat Kennedy had his own vision of a new world, he wasn't taking the risk with a barren planet, his was in the eternal spring and the clear mountain air of the Colombian Andes.

CHAPTER 18

THE CITY OF LONDON WAS GUILTY of receiving the proceeds of crime with the intent to permanently deprive the victims of those crimes of what was rightfully theirs. It was as guilty as Sedov's friends, of Wallace's conspiracy to defraud them of the money they had embezzled, just as Simmonds was an accomplice who had facilitated their use of stolen money, and just as the various banks that had transmitted that stolen money by wire.

Simmonds and his friends had been willing helpers. He himself had spent his life cleaning dirty money. Call it what you like, it was dirty. He had built a conduit via Belize to get money out of, or into, London.

He was in a manner of speaking a jobber and he had wanted out, the trouble was Simmo knew too much. Over the years his clientele had changed from British tax dodgers of various ilks, to Russian crooks and middlemen acting on behalf of a coterie of corrupt politicians and businessmen.

With the occult connivance of British politicians and bankers, the City of London had welcomed corrupt individuals from the multiple nations the defunct Soviet Union had spawned.

They came in all forms, from oligarchs who sponsored football clubs to those who listed companies stolen from the people of the USSR, who bought British politicians, their

political parties as well as institutions, universities, art galleries and newspapers.

In spite of Theresa May telling the House of Commons, ‘There is no place for these people, or their money, in our country ... and those who seek to do us harm, my message is simple: you are not welcome here,’ Russians and former Soviet citizens continued to flock to London and put their money by devious routes into British banks and businesses.

Barry Simmonds had known too much, but had left it too late to get out. Like the proverbial physician he had never to time to care for himself beyond the vital essentials and a few extras. Essentially he was honest, but naïve, or perhaps he simply turned his eyes from the wrongdoings he had got himself into.

At the other end of the scale was Sir Patrick Kennedy, a top A-List banker, one of those people who enjoyed advantages beyond those of ambassadors and diplomats, he even enjoyed the kind of privileges that many heads of smaller states could not afford. Tens of thousands depended directly on his decisions, hundreds of thousands indirectly.

Had the wind turned when Britain’s political classes realised that the City had become a hub for money laundering and prime property a vehicle for hiding the profits of crime and corruption?

The simple answer was no.

Perhaps openness was a virtue, even if it let kleptocrats and super rich oligarchs into the house in the guise of investors and philanthropists, agents of the Kremlin's authoritarian ambitions. Even with so much Russian money in the City, leaders had not woken up to the realisation that Russia could influence the UK's politics and institutions.

Circumventing the UK's much vaunted anti-laundering laws was child's play to men like Simmonds and his friends. Transparency ended when UK companies were owned by those registered elsewhere else, in places where ownership was opaque, where nominees abounded, companies with bank accounts in Latvia or Cyprus, where very few questions were asked, even though they were part of the EU and regulated in theory by the European Central Bank.

CHAPTER 19

WHEN THAT PERENNIAL ECONOMIST Nouriel Roubini—who came to fame after predicting the 2008 crisis, suddenly popped up again, John concluded his analysis that something extremely serious was in the making was not just another sign his growing pessimism as Ekaterina complained.

It was so evident this time around that few needed or even heeded Roubini's dramatic new warnings. It was clear to even the most obtuse that the shock to the global economy would have deeper and longer lasting effects than the 2008 global financial crisis, or perhaps even the Great Depression, both of which had taken time to impact the world economy.

This time around the effect of the new crisis resonated almost instantaneously, auguring the collapsed of world GDP and the frightening prospect of unemployment reaching 20%, as the US Treasury secretary had warned.

It came at a bad moment in the run up to the US presidential elections which could encourage America's enemies to attempt new adventures, not to speak of the troubles it could engender for Boris Johnson's Brexit.

It was a fatalistic moment, spurring certain to pull out their plans for the collapse they had feared and predicted. They included Cold War bunkers in South Dakota or in Eastern Europe that had been a long-standing attraction for tourists, and

which had more recently found a new life, refuges for collapsonauts of all ilks, preparing themselves for the coming apocalypse, the breakdown of law and order, which until so very recently had been the theme of Hollywood disaster movies featuring imaginary pandemics and zombie invasions.

Perhaps the spectre of all out nuclear war had receded, though there was still the risk of local war or an accident with people like Kim Jong-un and Ayatollahs of all shades. The real risk lay in civil disorder provoked by climate change, economic collapse, pandemics or natural risks, and there were plenty of high-net-worth individuals willing to invest in high-security shelters to protect themselves and their families from the multiple risks taking form on the horizon.

All of a sudden it was happening, and it wasn't difficult to imagine looters if not zombies roaming the streets. A new real estate market was born for enterprising individuals catering for the seemingly unwarranted fears of survivalists. But were they really that unwarranted?

Scattered across isolated regions of the US were the vestiges of past wars, army bases, strategic control centres, rocket silos, weapons storage facilities, vast underground structures in reinforced concrete with huge steel doors designed to resist the explosion of tactical nuclear weapons.

Amongst the many companies in INI's Panama portfolio was Salvos Holdings Inc., and as the name suggested it was a holding company specialised in the construction of community

retreats where the rich could weather the storm in the style and comfort they were used to.

They proposed sites in Colombia and Ireland offering the protection of mines cut deep into the mountains protected with automatic airlocks and blast doors. The ultimate safe havens.

But what was the use of protection if after the apocalypse there was nothing to permit the survivors to resume their lives. It was why the campuses, Salvator Mundi Ganay and Salvator Mundi Titian, seats of knowledge and learning, stood at the centre of Pat Kennedy's plans, the foundations around which future cities would be built. Arks that would save all that was valuable to human civilisation.

Pat did not have time for conspiracies—Nostradamus, biblical predictions or little green men and all that shit, but he did believe in the reality of economic crises, disease, natural disasters and above all human folly, it was why he saw planning and anticipation as the fundamental tenets of survival.

History was riddled with the collapse of empires and dynasties, and not only in the distant past, the most recent was the USSR, coming after the British Empire, the Third Reich, the Austro-Hungarian Empire, the Russian Imperial Empire.

The first death occurred in China January 11, then just three months later nearly 2,000,000 people had been infected and over 100,000 dead, it was impossible to predict what those figures would be come year end.

And when the lights went out, when the economy crashed for good, gold and paper money would be worthless. What was the use of a bank account when civilisation hit the wall. Arms would be of more use, to fight off Mad Max and his horde of desperados, have-nots, losers, pillagers, rapists and murderers. When the collapse came, the breakdown of the state, the end of civilisation as we know it, the only law would be that of the strong, as in the Bronze Age collapse, thought Pat Kennedy.

CHAPTER 20

ON-BOARD *LAS INDIAS*, THEY PASSED Port Said and entered the Suez Canal, the start of the romantic adventure Pat planned for his friends, an itinerary different to that of the Egyptologist Howard Carter, who arrived in Alexandria in 1891, at the age of 17, when Mohamed Tewfik Pasha was the Khedive of Egypt and the Sudan.

At that time Egypt was occupied by the British, a non-declared protectorate, theoretically part of the Ottoman Empire and its population had not yet reached ten million, now, as Las Indias docked, more than seven decades after the last British military adventure in 1956, its population exceeded 100 million.

In 1914, after the Ottoman Empire entered the war on the side of the Central Powers, Britain finally declared a protectorate over Egypt, the Khedive was deposed and Hussein Kamel was declared Sultan of Egypt.

Eight years later and only three days into a new excavation season, Howard Carter, stood before the first step of a newly discovered stairway, which little did he know led to the tomb of King Tutankhamun.

Carter immediately cabled George Edward Stanhope Molyneux Herbert, the 5th Earl of Carnarvon—his backer. ‘At last have made wonderful discovery in Valley; a magnificent

tomb with seals intact; re-covered same for your arrival; congratulation.'

Carter had been introduced him Carnarvon in 1908 who was visiting Egypt to avoid the cold damp London climate which did not favour his health. It was the start of an extraordinary relationship between two men, one that led to one of the most famous archaeological discoveries of all time.

Prior to the fame of Tutankhamun, the pharaoh was unknown to Egyptologists that is until to a small faience cup inscribed with his name was found by American Egyptologist Theodore Davis in 1905.

Once Carnarvon arrived, Carter made a small hole in the sealed doorway, inserted a candle and peered into the dark tomb. What they saw were 'wonderful things'.

Tutankhamun's mummy saw the light of day 3,247 years after the sickly pharaoh's premature death at the age of just 19.

From Suez Pat's group boarded a brief flight for Cairo where they visited the The Grand Egyptian Museum in Giza, a vast structure of concrete and glass, where after visiting the monumental works of the pharaohs they visited the extraordinary exhibition of Tutankhamen's treasures, presented for the first time together since Carter had entered into young pharaoh's burial chamber, stopping to marvel at the 3,300 year old death mask of the pharaoh weighing more than ten kilos of solid gold and encrusted with lapis lazuli.

In a manner of speaking he had achieved a degree of immortality, but not the kind Pat Kennedy was seeking.

The afterlife, or life after death, has always fascinated man, who until now had only been able to achieve this in the belief that our souls live forever, after our body's physical death.

In ancient Egypt, the tomb of the Pharaoh Menna. a scribe of the god Amun, helped explain the afterlife with a series of paintings and inscriptions. They showed Menna's heart being weighed in judgment to determine whether he had lived a good or bad life, a condition to being admitted to the afterlife before the god Osiris.

That evening standing before the pyramids in Giza, Pat and John could smile, their hearts would not be weighed, and perhaps they had found what the pharaohs had sought for thousands of years. The key to eternal life, at least very long life.

They looked at each other knowingly. Pat, his hair looking darker. John, his skin tighter. There was no denying Galenus was changing them.

As they looked at the monuments of the past, beneath which the pharaohs had prepared their ships for a voyage that never came, Pat Kennedy and John Francis stood on the brink of eternity. What lesson could the ancient Egyptians bring them?

The history of Egyptian medicine went back to 3100 BC and over those millennia many papyrus and countless inscriptions

on temples and monuments that told the story and recorded lists of plants and the names of famous physicians like Imothep.

It had commenced with Thoth, transformed into an Egyptian god, who was the founder of medicine and was believed to have been the author of the oldest Egyptian medical work with many of its remedies engraved on the walls of temples and monuments.

Life in ancient Egypt had been hard, very hard, and expectancy was low. But for the rich there were medicines described in the Ebers Papyrus, conserved in the library of Leipzig University in Germany.

The papyrus was the most important record of ancient Egyptian medical remedies and magical formulas. It described opium, cannabis, myrrh, frankincense, fennel, cassia, senna, thyme, henna, juniper, aloe, linseed and castor oil as well as magical incantations.

Many burial sites, including that of Tutankhamen and the sacred underground temple of the bulls at Saqqara, contained medicines and herbs, certain of which were steeped in wine, but unfortunately they were often no more than palliatives.

The realisation that Pat Kennedy had discovered the secret to life without end bore a terrible responsibility. In his hands he the held the power to control humanity.

Lifegen was still unraveling how Galenus worked on chromosomes. The functioning of telomeres was understood,

but why it reversed the ageing process of cells was still not fully explained.

‘Nature has,’ Pliny wrote, ‘in reality, bestowed no greater blessing on man than the shortness of life. The senses become dull, the limbs torpid, the sight, the hearing, the legs, the teeth, and the organs of digestion, all of them die before us…’

As they stood in the setting sun before the ancient pyramids they realised life had changed, theirs at least.

How could Pat Kennedy guard his secret, how could he protect himself and his chosen friends from those who coveted his power to live forever?

The first thing was to move the Gilgamesh Project and all those linked to it to Ciudad Salvatore Mundi in Colombia.

CHAPTER 21

NEWS FROM EUROPE WAS BAD, the pandemic raged, lock downs and quarantines were declared. With business decisions now pressing and Pat and his friends agreed to cut short their cruise and fly back to Beaulieu-sur-mer, leaving *Las Indias* to their wives and children to cruise down to Hurghada on the Red Sea then return to the Mediterranean with a pause in Crete and the Greek islands.

Pat had discussed at length the implications of extending life with John, a complex subject full of questions, and not only business. Philosophically, until that point in the existence of humanity, the duration of each individual's existence had been a divine decision.

Their experience left little doubt as to the extraordinarily positive effects of Galenus on their health and existence, what it meant in the long term was uncertain, but there was no point in waiting, of a common accord they decided it was time to set out a policy on Galenus.

A special meeting would be held on Sergei Tarasov's yacht, the *Cleopatra*, which lay anchored offshore, beyond Baie-des_Fourmis, facing Beaulieu, which was certainly more discreet for their meeting, safer, neither they nor Sergei wanted the media and other snoopers spying on their plans.

It was late afternoon and Pat was expecting his friends, Michel Morel and Henri Ducros from Lifegen for informal an informal meeting followed by drinks and diner, the object was to discuss what John called moral questions linked to the development, production and future of Galenus.

After their visit to Egypt, Pat and John were positively glowing with good health. They had flown back to Nice leaving *Las Indias* to continue the cruise down to Hurghada on the Red Sea.

The helicopter had been dispatched to pick up their friends at Sophia Antipolis, avoiding the traffic in and around Nice. It was an easy 20 minute from the heliport to the deck of the yacht.

Together with John, Pat wandered up to the fore deck after the pilot signaled he had taken off, waiting to spot the approach of the helicopter which would come in low over the sea avoiding the flight paths into and out of Nice International Airport.

Though it was a fine afternoon with perfect flying conditions, it was difficult to spot the helicopter against the background of the coastline and the hills. After a few minutes John spotted it flying low, very low, as it came around Cap-Ferrat.

Suddenly it rose, veered to one side, then to their horror plunged into the sea in a not very large spray of water, the rotor blades rising into the sky slowly flailing like the wings of a seabird seized in the jaws of an orca.

The small waves quickly faded, leaving nothing more than an insignificantly small scattering of debris.

CHAPTER 22

PAT AND JOHN STOOD SHOCKED, helpless, whilst the crew of the *Cleopatra* rushed to launch the tender, a fast rigid-hulled outboard.

There was nothing they could do. The emergency services had been alerted by the harbour master and a helicopter was already hovering above the site of the crash.

In an instant their two friends and Sergei Tarasov's pilot had died in an inexplicable accident, gone, forever.

Sergei arrived shortly after, he was shocked, his intention had been to use the helicopter that afternoon, then at the last minute he decided to drive from Monte Carlo, leaving the helicopter free to pick up Jean-Yves and Henri.

There was nothing they could do for the moment but wait for the helicopter manufacturer's preliminary investigation before jumping to conclusions leaving the enquiry to the civil aviation accident investigators who had arrived on the site.

Later that afternoon after divers had recovered the bodies and the accident enquiry team were finishing their initial investigation with the captain of the yacht, Pat and John took the cutter to Beaulieu and headed over to Lifegen where they announced the news to the shocked personnel.

Pat reassured the staff of his continued support and appointed the financial director as interim head, in the meantime they

were given three days paid leave and all nonessential staff were invited, under the watchful eyes of George Pyke's security team, to leave the premises after securing the laboratories and equipment leaving all company documents and material behind them in conformity with their employment contract conditions.

Pat then convened the Galenus team leader, Dr Caroline Fitzroy-Grossman, a specialist in pharmacology and the ageing process, who had worked directly under Michel Morel and Henri Ducros. They had met on many happier occasions. Caroline looked pale, her eyes were red, the terrible news had come as a brutal shock, but Pat had no time to lose, he had to secure the research data and the loyalty of Lifegen's key staff.

From Caroline's personal file, Pat knew she came from an Anglo-French family and had been brought up in Dublin where she had studied at Trinity College before continuing at Inserm in France.

She was still young, but had a brilliant academic record, and now her value to Lifegen had suddenly become vital.

'Caroline, I know this is a very difficult moment, but I'd like you to know we are counting on you and can assure on our backing. This is a tragedy for our friend's families, it's a tragedy for us, but life must go on. What I'm proposing is a directorship for you. You don't have to reply now.

'Thank you Pat, you can count on my loyalty.'

‘Excellent, for the moment we have to attend to the most urgent matters, then, in a few days we can talk again.’

Pat’s next task would be to secure the future of Lifegen, owned by a Dublin based holding, and all the rights linked to the Galenus molecule.

CHAPTER 23

IN THE YEAR THAT HAD PASSED since Lola Barton had laid the foundation stone at the construction site, work had progressed and Campus Salvator Mundi was taking form. It lay at the entrance to a valley to the west of the picturesque town of Curiti, between Barichara and the Chicamocha Canyon, on the Cordillera Oriental of the Colombian Andes.

It was hailed as the site of a new scientific campus and research centre that would at some point become the economic driver of Ciudad Salvator Mundi, Pat Kennedy's city of the future, the brainchild of his friend Tom Barton.

The stone marked the centre of a large plaza, which in the future would be surrounded on the north and south sides by shops, bars and restaurants. To the west side of the plaza would be a cultural centre with a theatre and concert hall, and to the east facing the mountain would be the administrative buildings of the campus, all of which was conceived in an architecture more futuristic than, but inspired by, the fine old colonial towns that lay in the region between Bogota and Bucaramanga.

The campus once completed would include a multi-sport centre with a riding club and stables. It would be protected by a paramilitary security force, its first units already patrolling the perimeter of the site to ward off unwelcome visitors, which would a some future point form the core of a defence force, an

essential element to ensure the survival of the city in times of danger.

The plans called for a city that would function with energy entirely generated by solar and wind power. The climate of the Cordillera was generous, 300 days of sunshine graced the summits of its peaks and the valleys through which flowed clear mountain streams, an earthly paradise caressed by gentle winds.

Beyond the campus site lay a previously disused road that led up the valley to the abandoned mine, where Minerales Andinos had commenced construction work, with heavy trucks now rumbling up and down the newly resurfaced road.

Climatic conditions projected for 2100 were now expected in 2050, and soon large regions of the planet, occupied by men for hundreds and thousands of years, would become inhabitable. Ciudad Salvator Mundi promised Pat Kennedy and his friends a better, safer, future, far from sea coasts eaten by erosion, encroaching deserts scorched by the sun, far from the teeming hungry masses and their diseases.

Pat had seen the desertic region of the Alta Guajira had spread, glimpsed the dystopian future of the Gulf of Venezuela, and the flood of men and women fleeing from the dysfunctional state of Nicolas Maduro.

At the outset Pat had quietly set to work on his project, not far from Lola's home, Barichara, a small colonial town in the Cordillera Oriental, a couple of hours drive to the south of Bogota.

To the local inhabitants the question of research into what was not very clear. The project was variously described as a centre for the study new energies sources—solar, wind and hydrogen, and especially the development of new storage batteries, given the abundance of naturally occurring sodium salts in the region.

It was concentrated near to an abandoned salt mine that lay in a narrow valley, cut into the flank of the mountains, 20 kilometres from Barichara, near Curiti—a somewhat smaller town.

The mine and the land that surrounded it had been in Lola Barton's family as long as could be remembered, exploited by a minerals company owned by her father, Don Pedro de Heredia, until it was no longer profitable. Without the attraction of the salt cathedral in the Zipaquira mine to the north, it was closed down and forgotten, apart from rare visits by local students and geologists.

Since the early part of the year, the mine had been the site of new activity as construction workers moved in to build a research pilot for sodium-ion batteries, a type of rechargeable battery, similar to the better known lithium-ion type, but using other minerals extracted from the salt deposits.

It was a very low profile affair, few announcements in the local press and media—the kind of short reports new investments usually attracted, and few questions were asked. The people of the surrounding region were tight lipped when it came to the affairs of Don Pedro.

To one side of the compound was a helicopter pad and a couple of hangers and further down the valley an already existing airstrip, one than was used frequently by Tom Barton and Don Pedro, who didn't need reminding of the dangers of road transport in the Cordillera Orientale—Lola's parents had died in a tragic road accident when she was a child on the treacherous mountain road to Bucaramanga.

What would have the raised eyebrows of an observant outsider were the vast iron doors situated at the main entry to the mine, much larger and solid than were needed to protect a salt mine or even an industrial research centre.

The new buildings that were springing up in the compound leading to the mine were squat concrete nondescript blocks with heavy metal shutters to protect the windows.

Another of the features that would have surprised visitors to the mines galleries, for the moment at least, was the absence of any of the kind of activities associated with mineral extraction, transformation, workshops or research laboratories. However further into the mine, many large galleries were being transformed into what would be storage spaces for materials and vehicles, maintenance workshops and more curiously, large cold storage areas.

In addition closer investigation would have revealed power generation sets connected to ventilation shafts and fuel storage cisterns much larger than would have been needed for a normal research establishment.

* * *

The real purpose behind Sociedad de Desarrollo Minerales Andinos was the construction of a sanctuary, a shelter, or more prosaically a bolt hole for the Clan, that is Pat Kennedy and his close friends.

To many the idea would have seemed absurd, far fetched, but Pat Kennedy's vision of the future was clouded by his knowledge of how fragile the world had become, from many points of view, and he reasoned if the Maya had survived by fleeing into the safety of the jungle, why shouldn't civilisation seek survival in the shelter of distant mountains.

'Why not on a Caribbean island?' he had asked John Francis.

'The trouble there,' John explained, 'is most islands would have difficulties in fending off intruders, unless they were extremely isolated, whereas the Cordillera Oriental,' as Tom Barton had suggested, 'was far from the sea, and at an altitude of 1,400 metres it could be fortified like a medieval castle with its access to the surrounding land where food could be grown. Then once the danger passed, it would be easier to kick-start life again.'

It seemed logical, besides, it was not as if Colombia would be the target of a nuclear power or any other power, with perhaps the exception of Venezuela, *un perro sin dientes*, according to Lola's father Don Pedro.

In any case threats came from many other sources, economic, political and environmental collapse, pandemics and natural disasters.

Pat wasn't the only one, the world elite was looking to survive, the mega-rich, royals, politicians, bankers, hedge fund managers, showbiz and sporting personalities along with their families, personnel and medical teams.

* * *

The *Centro de Desarrollo de Minerales Andinos* would require food and medical reserves, capable of providing for the needs of each individual for a minimum of one year, stored underground in refrigerated store rooms.

In addition to those essential needs were generators, vehicles, telecommunications systems, spare parts, enough of everything to survive an apocalyptic event and restart life.

The plans covered fresh and waste water systems, a hospital and an operating theatre, a well equipped medical laboratory, a library, a bakers, a dairy farm and even an ark with essential domestic animals—dairy cattle, sheep, pigs, chickens, plants and seeds.

There was of course a paramilitary security force—former army personnel selected and trained by George Pyke, the Clans security specialist, with state of the art weapons capable of defending the city from marauders and the desperate fleeing Bogota or other nearby cities when the moment came.

Deep in the ground would be reserves of fuel, oil and gas, diesel generators, radios, IT equipment, vehicles, drones, helicopters, light aircraft, boats, solar panels, wind generators, pumps, tools, tractors, fertilizer, medical and pharmaceutical supplies, a library of books and maps, spare parts, a bakery, a butchers, in short everything needed to ensure survival, at least 12 months, during which time they would have to become autonomous, autarchic.

Daily activities would be conducted in the research centre buildings, the base around which a campus would be built, which would be linked by an underground railway to the mine and its galleries, where last resort shelters would be cut deep into the bedrock, providing temporary living quarters and the storage of reserves, sufficient for the survival of up to 2,000 individuals.

Columbia, like its neighbours, was blessed with some of the most favourable conditions on Earth for renewable energy in the form of wind, solar and geothermal power. Already nearby Costa Rica was a model, the only country supplied with 100% renewable electricity.

It was a vital factor in Pat Kennedy's investment plan, cheap and abundant energy. Colombia, with its 1.14 million square kilometres, four times great than the British Isles, was unburdened by an ageing population like the UK and its long list of social problems. It was still a new world, one of vast opportunities and resources, even five centuries after Alonso de Ojeda, a companion of Columbus, had set his eyes on its coast.

Cartagena was its first city, founded in 1533 by Pedro de Heredia, an ancestor of Lola Barton's, a city that became Spain's most powerful military base for the exploration and conquest of the New World.

Pat Kennedy's Clan now included three Spanish speaking families, first there was that of Lola Barton's, whose grandfather, don Pedro was a Colombian grandee, descended directly from Pedro de Heredia, and was a wealthy well-connected figure. Then came Liam and Camille Clancy, followed by Dee O'Connelly and his partner Anna Basurko, they together with Pat would be the founding fathers of Ciudad Salvator Mundi.

Pat was not alone in his plans, in fact it was a growing business with similar such bunkers being built in New Zealand, in the US and Europe, often in Cold War bunkers, fallout shelters, rocket silos, in the Swiss Alps, in the Rockies and in former Soviet East Block countries, wherever adequate protection was possible.

Survivalists planned to build compact fully autonomous, defensible shelters, part of which were deep in abandoned mines and bunkers, which would act as last resort citadels, inner baileys, keeps, as in European medieval castles. And as in such a castle there were spaces for services, defence, communication, utilities, accommodation, dining halls, shops, schools and meeting halls.

* * *

Unknown to all but a few, the Centro de Desarrollo had a twin, situated in Ireland, not far from Dublin, in the Wicklow Mountains, built on the same model, around an old lead and silver mine.

Pat, as any careful planner, had no intention of putting all his eggs in one basket, or in one mine. Colombia had the advantage of being far from war zones and was almost an inconsequential player in big power geopolitics, of little strategic value, though at the same time distance could be a disadvantage. It was why Pat chose Ireland as a second site, it was an island, a fairly big one, nearer to Europe, but separated by two seas, and was an equally inconsequential geopolitical player of little strategic value.

In a moment of danger with his intercontinental jet, he and his friends could cross continents and oceans, from Hong Kong to Dublin, or from London to Bogota, where they could ride out the storm or in a worse case scenario start again.

CHAPTER 24

pAT BURSTING WITH ENERGY and enjoying his new found form had overlooked Simmo. His mind had been fixed on his own pressing needs, not only his health, but his family, his clan and his business. Of course the Wallace Codex had been vital to the development of Galenus, thanks to the work of LifeGen and the powerful tools used in their research work, but he owed Simmonds.

Simmo's silence not only struck Pat as abnormal, but in addition his mobile phone seemed disconnected, strange for someone who was waiting for a big payday. Pat called Henrique da Souza in Sao Paulo and asked him to fly to Belize City and find out what had happened to the lawyer.

Pat Kennedy was not the only person intrigued by Simmonds, there was also Arkady Demitriev, but not for the same reasons. Demitriev was not in the least intrigued by Simmonds' whereabouts, after all it was he who had ordered the lawyer's gruesome remains to be dumped in the jungle swamp, off the road between the Guatemalan border and Belmopan.

Demitriev was more concerned about the clues that linked the defunct lawyer to Scott Fitznorman, the Parisian fine arts dealer who Simmonds had met in San Sebastian during his sudden and unexplained visit to Spain.

Demitriev decided to pay a visit to Simmonds' place a few kilometres outside of Belize City.

The large colonial house appeared to be locked up, but as he peered through the window an elderly woman appeared on the side of the verandah. She was what they called a Mestizo, descendants of the Spanish-Mexican families that had arrived in Belize at the beginning of the 20th century, now the country's second largest community after the Creoles. She and her husband had worked for Simmonds for 30 odd years.

'Can I help you?' she asked.

'That depends,' replied Demitriev putting on a smile. 'Can you tell me if Mr Simmonds is around?'

'May I ask who you are?'

Demitriev produced something that resembled an official ID card.

She looked at it, without looking at it.

Tall, blond and arrogant, Demitriev looked menacing. She and her family were living in the hope that Simmonds would return, they totally dependent on him living in a small but comfortable house on the edge of his property.

'I've been asked by his family to look for him, they've had no news for sometime,' announced Demitriev.

The woman hesitated.

‘Do you work for him?’

‘Yes, I’m Rosanna Mendez, his housekeeper, my husband Felix is his driver.’

‘I see.’

‘Mr Simmonds has not come back,’ she continued tears welling up in her eyes. ‘It’s already two months without any news. We don’t know what to do, we’ve reported it to the police, but they’re doing nothing as usual.’

‘Maybe I can help. That’s why I’m here. Who is paying the bills, your wages?’

‘We send everything to his office in Fort George.’

‘Oh.’

‘Yes, Miss Scmitt, his assistant is looking after all that, but it’s very complicated.’

‘Could I look inside. His family in the UK are worried.’

The woman hesitated, she was suspicious, then opened the door with a key and let him in.

Everything seemed normal, orderly and clean. The house was large and comfortable, evidently Simmo had lived in style, like a latter day colonial gentleman. She showed him the living room and Simmo’s office. There was a laptop on the table surrounded by pens, pencils, papers and several books including a couple on pre-Columbian history and codeces

‘Perhaps I can borrow his computer, it will help us to get things moving,’ he said picking it up with its power cable. ‘My friends in Belmopan can help us, I know the chief justice, he’s a good friend.’

Rosanna stiffened at mention of authority and especially the chief justice, Kenneth Benjamin, then nodded compliantly. Belmopan was the official capital of Belize, built inland fifty years earlier after the coast was ravaged by a hurricane. A small town of less than twenty thousand.

‘Look, here is my card,’ he said more softly. ‘Don’t worry, as soon as I’ve checked this I’ll return it or hand it over to the police.’

Before she could change her mind Demitriev turned his heels and headed for his car with the laptop under his arm and what looked like a thin and rather worn address book that had lain next to it on the desk in his other hand.

As soon as his car disappeared she called Simmonds’ downtown office and informed Maria Scmitt of the visit.

CHAPTER 25

BACK AT HIS PLACE IN NORTH SIDE, Demitriev looked at the laptop, as a GRU agent cracking access codes was one of his skills—dehashing simple passwords.

With a rainbow table of preformulated alphanumeric hashed passwords, he didn't, unlike with a password dictionary, have to match the password. He simply had to match the entry it created to match the correct password.

But that would be a long process.

Instead he turned his attention to the well thumbed address book he had swiped from Simmonds' place. It looked at least ten years old and contained jumbles of names and numbers, pages full of numbers, plus what appeared to be internet sites, servers, cloud data storage accounts, user names, passwords and email addresses.

Turning the pages to the more recent entries he spotted the name of the company they had used for the Ambergris Golf Resort. He deducted the names were those of companies Simmonds had set-up over the years. The rest of the details were access codes and account numbers, all he had to do was unravel the details. The question was where to start, there were hundreds of references and it would take time.

To begin with he started by looking for the access code for Simmonds' laptop. Scrutinising the pages of the address book he noted a pattern. There were numerous entries commencing with barry04021975. Barry was a shortened form of Simmonds' first name, Bernard, the number evidently his birthday, which was followed by another name, for example google, then an email address.

He powered up the laptop. The welcome page demanded the code. He typed in barry04021975. It worked first time. Suddenly Demitriev's task seemed simpler. He began by exploring the files and images.

It took several days to make some sense of Simmonds' life and business, to piece together the silent clues, one by one. Most of the data concerned his business, the companies he had set-up for hundreds of clients, including those for Vishnevsky's friends, and their bank accounts.

One of the last entries was Cavendish Holdings, a Cayman Island company, set-up on the very same date of Simmonds' visit to San Sebastian in Spain. The entry also indicated Cavendish Holdings held an account at the Anglo-Dutch Commonwealth Bank.

Demitriev made a quick search and discovered the bank was based on the Caribbean island of Dominica, more precisely the Commonwealth of Dominica, a small independent former British colony, the very same country that should have provided investor passports for Sedov's friends in Moscow.

As yet unknown to Demitriev, the Anglo-Dutch bank had been the recipient of the one million dollars paid to Cavendish Holdings by Pat Kennedy, an advance payment for the Wallace Codex.

Demitriev also discovered the details and correspondence relating to the liquidation of Wallace's estate. Armed with this information he decided his first priority would be a visit to the office of Simmonds & Young, situated in Fort George, a few blocks from his own place in Belize City, second he would find out more about Cavendish Holdings and its account at the Anglo-Dutch bank.

* * *

Life had become complicated for Barry Simmonds after his partner Gordon Young had retired. Theirs had been a good business, but alone Simmo had slowly lost interest in the firm. Maria Scmitt had been too young and his attempts to find a buyer had only met with frustration after a well-connected government official, Wilfred Thompson, proposed his son as a new partner with a buy-in offer well below what Simmo had been hoping for.

Demitriev found Simmonds law firm on Barrack Road, which had been made famous after being cited in the Paradise Papers. The office was a small modern building with a brass plaque fixed on an imposing door announcing Young & Simmonds Partners, Solicitors.

The Russian, as a resident of Belize City, was very familiar with the brass plaques announcing lawyer firms in the Fort George district, where any enterprising would-be money launderer or tax dodger could acquire an IBC offshore firm with directors, an address and a bank account for 700 dollars upwards and few questions asked.

The door was locked. He rang the bell, twice. After a couple of minutes a spyhole slide open and he was inspected. Belize City was a dangerous town and offices and businesses were careful about who knocked on their door.

The door opened. A slim, plain, but not unattractive, woman of about thirtyish opened the door.

‘Can I help you?’

‘I’m looking for Mr Simmonds.’

‘He’s not here, perhaps I can help, I work with him, Maria Scmitt,’ she said introducing herself a little sharply.

She was Simmonds’ legal assistant, Maria Scmitt, probably from a Belizean Mennonite background with a name like that, thought Demitriev.

‘May I come in?’

Somewhat reluctantly she invited him into the office. It a typical lawyers office—staid, conservative furniture, a Law Society Plaque, framed admission certificates and a few framed graduation photographs on dark wood paneled walls. A wall

airconditioner softly rattled in the background. Scmitt worked behind an area in the reception closed by a counter. A PC screen sat on her desk, behind which was a printer, a photo copier and filing cabinets stood against the wall.

Through one of the open doors Demitriev spied a large office, probably that of Simmonds, dominated by an old fashioned leather topped bureau with a swivel chair, behind which was a bookcase with volumes of legal records and law books.

The office was well ordered, Simmonds was obviously meticulous with no files or papers languishing on his antique mahogany bureau, no photographs, just a worn leather desk pad with a glass paperweight and a few pens and pencils neatly aligned.

He presented his visiting card that informed her he was a consular representative of the Russian Federation at the Mexican Embassy in Belize, where the Federation's diplomatic mission in the country was housed.

'Mr Simmonds has some ongoing business with us and I'm here to follow up.'

'I'm afraid Mr Simmonds is not available,' she announced guardedly. 'During his absence ... I'm taking care of his affairs.'

'Absent?'

'Yes, he's … unavailable ….'

There was no other choice but for Demitriev to inform her of his business.

‘Mr Simmonds was working with some important Russian investors and we’d like to speak with him.’

She then repeated the same story he had already heard from Simmonds’ housekeeper.

‘For the moment it seems difficult. I’ve been in contact with the authorities, for the moment they’ve not acted, the police department has suggested he’s gone abroad.’

She hesitated for a moment then added, ‘Have you anything to do with gentleman who came looking for him this morning.’

‘Oh!’

‘A Brazilian gentleman, his name is ...,’ she said searching for his card, ‘Henrique da Souza.’

‘A Brazilian! What did he want?’

‘He wanted to speak to him of behalf of Sir Patrick Kennedy.’

‘What did you tell him?’

‘Nothing, our work is confidential.’

‘Perhaps you are aware Mr Simmonds was in contact with Sir Patrick?’ said Demitriev testing her.

‘I do believe they communicated. As for Mr Simmonds’ movements, he is very discreet. Though it’s strange his passport is still here.’

‘May I see it?’

She had nothing to lose, and possibly something to learn. She took a key and opened a drawer in Simmonds bureau, took out the passport and handed it to Demitriev.

He flipped through the pages and saw recent stamps proof that he had recently visited Panama, Spain and Switzerland. They indicated Simmonds’ port of entry into Switzerland was Geneva.

A thought then occurred to him. ‘Does Mr Simmonds hold another passport?’

‘Yes,’ she replied. ‘He has also a Belizean passport.’

‘What is happening to his day to day business?’

She looked at him, weighing him up. ‘I’m taking care of that, Mr Simmonds was in discussions with Mr Wilfred Thompson with a view to opening the partnership to his son. Mr Thompson is a government official in Belmopan with the prime minister’s office.’

‘You say was?’

‘Yes, Mr Simmonds’ absence has delayed things. So I’m carrying on as usual, internet orders for off-the-shelf IBCs,

incorporation, statutes registration and other the legal obligations are standard procedures. I'm a qualified solicitor, I take care of our business whenever Mr Simmonds is absent.

'It's a long time since he's gone.'

She bowed her head uneasily.

'He had business in Ambergris, but with the pandemic it's been suspended.'

You could say that again, thought Demitriev.

'I'm worried, perhaps he's in trouble, there are some very bad people here. There's also Mr Wallace—he was a client of ours, he was involved in the Ambergris Golf Resort development, he's dead now. Then there's Mr Vishnevsky, his body was found on the beach near San Pedro, Mr Simmonds knew him well.'

'I see. Where is Mr Da Souza staying?'

'At the Radisson.'

'Don't worry, everything will no doubt work out,' he told her soothingly. He then bid her goodbye and left heading in the direction of the hotel.

CHAPTER 26

HENRIQUE HAD SPENT THE AFTERNOON at the Central Bank of Belize where he paid a courtesy call at the Office of the Governor, expressing INI's interest in the country's investment plans. He also discussed Young & Simmonds and the mysterious disappearance of its last remaining partner, Barry Simmonds, who had been active in the incorporation of IBCs on behalf of certain investors. The governor promised she would contact the Ministry of National Security, which was the Police Department's governing body, and return to him as soon as she had some news.

Walking back to the Radisson, Henrique reflected on the changes that had brought him from Hong Kong to Belize. He was effectively a political exile in Brazil, unsure he would ever be able to return to home to Macau or Hong Kong, see his family friends again.

It was coming up to a year since he had fled Hong Kong following the democracy demonstrations. The oppressive new laws had been introduced by the pro-Beijing Hong Kong government and applied to crush dissent and stifle freedom of speech, targeting pro-democracy journalists and politicians, academics, protesters, teachers and other professionals.

Henrique was forced to watch from the other side of the world as activists like Joshua Wong and Agnes Chow were jailed for

campaigning against the sweeping national security laws, criminalising overseas action as ‘collusion with foreign powers’.

As a political fugitive, Henrique feared the long arm of Beijing’s Ministry of State Security (MSS), its Ministry of Public Security (MPB), and their emanations, which operated very differently to the Russians. The Chinese were more bent on economic, commercial and technological secrets. Their favoured methods were infiltration and cyber intrusion, the latter being preferred by the Peoples Liberation Army (PLA).

Henrique was certain the China’s overseas intelligence agency, the Joint Staff Intelligence Bureau (JSD), was observing him.

Those structures were more opaque than any Western intelligence services, for several reasons, starting with the Chinese language, followed by the Chinese diaspora, which Xi Jingpin described as China’s ‘magic weapons’, willing to do Beijing’s bidding.

They operated differently, undermining countries and businesses from within, a gradual process of wearing down and winning over their enemies, which did not mean they did not employ violence, kidnapping and assassination when necessary.

He had little choice but to turn his attention to his new role as Pat Kennedy’s emissary for the development of INI’s business plans in Latin America.

Arriving at the hotel he wondered what his next move would be. He had discovered little about Simmonds' mysterious disappearance since his arrival and was learning fast how impunity allowed violence to flourish. Like in nearby Mexico, or Brazil—his new home, police and justice were tools of political power. Homicides were barely investigated, almost never solved, and missing persons were of little interest.

At the hotel a message was awaiting him from a certain Mike Watson. Apparently news travelled faster than appearances in Belize.

He called the number and Watson proposed they meet at the hotel bar the same evening.

* * *

Later as Henrique da Souza met up with Watson at the Radisson, Demitriev returned to the offices of Young & Simmonds, he was accompanied by one of his helpers for whom opening the street door was child's play.

Once inside his man opened the drawer in Simmonds' bureau and Demitriev helped himself to Simmonds' passport, a file on Cavendish Holdings, da Souza's visiting card and that of Scott Fitznorman in Paris.

They then slipped out onto the poorly light street, leaving the office almost as they found it, carefully closing the door and disappearing into the night.

The whole break-in had taken barely ten minutes.

* * *

Watson told Henrique the story of the Ambergris Golf Resort and beachfront condominium north of San Pedro on the peninsula's Caribbean coast. It had been a guaranteed winner until the pandemic hit the tourist industry and the investment hit a brick wall.

A hard-skinned investigative journalist, Watson had discovered that the investors were friends of Igor Vishnevsky and Arkady Demitriev. Vishnevsky had ended up dead on the beach opposite the incomplete condos, half eaten by bull sharks, he had been guilty of neglect, too much time spent living it up in Cancun and Tulum nightspots whilst George Wallace, the Russians' local partner, robbed them blind

'So what was Simmonds' role?'

'He was one of the promoters, he'd acquired the site, which is worthless now, at least for the next couple or more years to come.'

'What about his legal assistant?'

'Scmitt, she joined him a couple of years ago. Bit of a mystery, has a place in the Renaissance Tower, near the Ramada.'

'Any relationship with Simmonds?'

‘Seems to keep to herself.’

‘So what happened to him?’

‘He lost everything.’

‘Where is he now?’

‘Well I was hoping you could tell me that.’

CHAPTER 27

THE FOLLOWING DAY SHORTLY AFTER LUNCH, Demitriev left his place in Belize City and walked over to Simmonds' office. It was closed. Perhaps Scmitt had business outside.

Later that afternoon he returned, but the office was still closed.

The same evening he received an abrupt coded instruction from Moscow ordering him to report to the GRU headquarters for a meeting with Sedov, immediatly.

It was seven in the morning local time when Demitriev disembarked at Sheremetyevo International Airport in Moscow. After the 12 hour flight from Cancun he was knackered, the government was too tight to pay a business class seat and Sedov who had convoked him was too pissed off to even think about upgrading him.

His recall to Moscow was under the guise of a training course at Cherepovets, a desolate industrial town near Lake Ladoga, a thousand kilometres to the north of Moscow. The reality was his return had been triggered by his report that Henrique da Souza, Kennedy's man, and Watson, a Cancun journalist, had met in Belize, sounding the alarm bells.

Sedov had been warned by the head of the Second Directorate that a scandal linked to VTB was to be avoided at all cost. It was a delicate moment, changes were afoot, and any leak would provide ammunition for the opposition and dissidents, especially coming after the failed attack on Navalny; the troubles in Belarus; the election in Moldavia where the pro-Moscow incumbent had been dumped; and rumours circulating about Vladimir Putin health concerns which had set social networks buzzing.

Valery Solovey—a political scientist and historian, until recently a Kremlin insider, had declared in an interview that Putin’s repressive tactics wouldn’t hold up as regime changes were on their way at a moment when laws were being prepared to make Putin a life senator once he resigned as president.

On arrival at the Main Intelligence Directorate, a faceless modern building on Grizodubovoy Ulitsa in the north-west of Moscow, Demitriev reported to Sedov's office.

Following a debriefing, during which Demitriev reported on Simmonds links to Sir Patrick Kennedy, Anna Basurko and Scott Fitznorman, he was instructed to pursue his investigations, wherever they led with daily reports for Sedov’s eyes only. He would be provided with a new identity, documentation, funds and authorisations to travel into the Schengen area, where, if necessary, he would be backed up by locally based agents.

Demitriev left the offices with a huge sense of relief, a sudden recall to Moscow was always a cause for alarm. Thankfully he was excused the trip to Cherepovets, which he suspected was a warning, a posting there would be an assured end to his international career. Now he could look forward to a weekend in the capital whilst preparations were made for his trip to France and Switzerland to follow-up his leads.

CHAPTER 28

MARIA SCMITT HADN'T WAITED AROUND to see what happened next. By the time Demitriev learnt the bird had flown, she was already checking into the Mirador de Dalt Vila, a boutique hotel overlooking the Mediterranean, ten thousand kilometres from Belize City, on the Spanish island of Ibiza.

After inspecting her room she collapsed onto the bed and slept until early evening. The journey from Belize to Panama, London, Madrid and finally to Ibiza had been long and stressful after her flight from Belize following Demitriev's visit to Young & Simmonds law offices.

The Russian's visit had come nearly three days earlier, shortly after that of Henrique da Souza's, which was alarming enough. But what had really frightened Maria was the disappearance of the passport and documents relating to Cavendish Holdings.

Simmonds had warned her about Demitriev who was not a simple attaché, but an intelligence agent and extremely dangerous. He warned her of how her telephone could be traced and how in the case of danger she destroy the SIM card and throw the phone into the Haulover Creek.

It was why she left almost empty handed for Panama City using her British passport where she boarded a flight to London. From there, without contacting her aunt, who she did not want to alarm, she flew to Madrid on her Belize passport, then to Denia where she took the ferry to Ibiza.

Maria Scmitt's story was not ordinary, even in Belize, once a small British colony that had been the scene of many turbulent events. Her mother's parents were Mennonites, part of a small community that had founded Shipyard in the Orange Walk District in the north of Belize in the late 1950s after arriving from Mexico.

Ursula Scmitt was just twenty years old when she met Barry Simmonds a couple of years after he had arrived in newly independent country. To the dismay of her family she soon fell under the charms of the Englishman, a young lawyer in Belize City. Her family, Mennonites, strict Anabaptist traditionalists, disapproved of her relationship with an outsider and expelled her from their community when she became pregnant. Ursula died from an infection soon after giving birth, and the child, Maria, disowned by her grandparents, which left her broken hearted young father the task of bringing her up alone.

Simmonds confided her to the care of his housekeeper and when Maria reached school age she was sent to the International School in Belize City.

On her reaching the age of ten Simmonds realised his daughter spoke bad English and as an Englishman he knew—like John le Carré, 'an Englishman is branded by his tongue'. It was why he took his daughter to London where he enrolled Maria in an English girls' school in Westminster, leaving her under the care of his widowed sister May Grafton, who was several years older than him.

May, Maria's childless aunt, owned a very large six level townhouse on St Georges Square in Pimlico, left to her by her husband, a successful businessman who had died young in a tragic boating accident. May never remarried and lived on the street and lower level garden floors of the house, the rest was divided into several modern apartments which she rented for short term leases to government bodies in and around Westminster for their visitors from the more distant counties.

The house was within walking distance of Maria's new school, the Grey Coat Hospital School for girls. At first the change was a shock, but she soon adapted to her new life in London, where encouraged by her aunt she made new friends, only returning to Belize for holidays with her father and the Mendez family. At 18 she went on to study at Goldsmiths in London to become a solicitor like her father.

After Gordon Young, Simmonds' law firm partner, retired to England, Maria joined her father in Belize as his legal assistant to learn the arcane workings of offshore business law.

Simmonds, who, like his sister, had always been been very protective with Maria, kept her at a safe distance from his less scrupulous business associates, especially Wallace and his Russian friends. As far as those who met with him were concerned, Maria was either the daughter of distant relatives in the UK, or the family of the Mendez couple.

Maria was discreet like her father and their profession, avoiding the chatter of the town's people. On the one hand she

considered herself English, like her father and aunt, and on the other very close to the Mendez family with whom she had grown up speaking Spanish.

Simmonds never hid from his daughter the story of her Mennonite mother and grandparents and had insisted she learnt Hochdeutsch at Grey Coat Language College, an extension of her school in London, where naturally she was an excellent student. Growing up in a multilingual environment had introduced her to a potpourri of languages including Maya dialects, Garifuna and of course Belizean Creole.

During her schooling and studies in England she rarely spoke of Belize, previously known as British Honduras, a small, distant, not very rich, former colony that had nothing special to boast about. She had overheard snidey comments about her father and discovered the unflattering sobriquet 'small-time' lawyer, even from his sister when she became annoyed by the way he risked his money and his daughter's future in uncharacteristic property investments such as the Ambergris Golf Resort.

At times Maria preferred to identify herself with her somewhat haughty, sometimes overweening, Aunty May Grafton in Westminster, than her father, whom she nevertheless loved, even in his dead-end backwater—Belize.

When Simmonds business start to go sour, as May predicted it would, he confessed his concerns to Maria, afraid of what might happened if his Russian friends became unpleasant.

That changed after his mysterious impromptu trip to Europe. He returned bearing good news, his fortunes had changed and he announced they would soon start a new life in Spain. He told her of his deal with Kennedy and the money that would be his and her insurance policy if things went wrong, as they soon did.

* * *

The next day Maria headed down to the BBVA branch in Ibiza Town to pick up the poste restante statements held for a local holiday rental company—Maya Sol Villas S.L., which owned his retirement villa, situated just outside of Santa Eulalia del Rio, which until then had been rented to English and Northern European holiday makers, however, outside of the high season, what with the pandemic, it had found few takers.

Maya Sol Villas was owned by a British Virgin Islands trust also set up by her father, which offered numerous advantages for foreign residents.

Completed and furnished a year earlier the villa was in perfect condition, the pool and gardens maintained by the agency, leaving Maria little else to do than settle the maintenance charges, collect the few belongings she had brought with her from Belize and move in.

Simmonds had also had the foresight to open foreign residents bank accounts with the BBVA in his own and Maria's name, which allowed Maria to settle in without attracting to much attention. Her plan was simple—keep a low profile whilst she

figured how and when she would make her next move, which was meeting with Sir Patrick Kennedy and claiming what was due on the Wallace Codex.

CHAPTER 29

TWO DETAILS IN DEMITRIEV'S DEBRIEFING report drew Sedov's attention. The first was the entry stamp in Simmonds' passport recording his visit to Geneva, and the second was the visiting card of Jean-Louis Favre, a customer relations executive at the Geneva Freeport.

The passport traced Simmonds' last movements, starting with his visit to Panama City, where Demitriev's man had observed him visit PKB Banca Privada, part of the New York based Warburg Pincus private equity bank. From there he had been tailed back to his hotel ... from where he had disappeared.

That mystery was now solved. The passport confimed Simmonds had indeed visited Geneva and possibly the Freeport. Other stamps confirmed he had left Geneva the following day and arrived in Madrid, staying two days in Spain.

There at the Hotel de Londres y Inglaterra in San Sebastian he had certainly met the archaeologist, Anna Basurko, her friends, Fitznorman—the fine arts dealer, and Sir Patrick Kennedy—head of the INI banking group, however, the question as to the precise purpose of their meeting remained a mystery.

A quick search in the GRU's database turned up newspaper reports showing that all three had been in Belize the previous year, where they had visited the archaeological site of Altun Ha renowned for the discovery in 1968 of a jade head of Kinich

Ahau—the Maya Sun God. There were also photographs of their visit to the Museum of Belize in the company of a renowned French archaeologist—René Veil.

The museum, a former prison, housed a rich collection of Maya artifacts, which had evidently interested Kennedy, a very wealth and well-known collector of antiquities and fine art.

One hypothesis was Simmonds had found something of interest to Kennedy, but what?

That he would find out.

As for the Geneva Freeport, it had been at the heart of a rocambolesque dispute involving Dmitry Rybolovlev, a Russian oligarch, a person interest to the intelligence services. Rybolovlev had built a world-class collection of 38 masterpieces, including artworks by Leonardo da Vinci, Picasso, Rothko, Modigliani and Monet.

There was nothing very unusual in that, rich men collected art. More interesting was Rybolovlev's art dealer, Yves Bouvier, who was none other than the owner of the Freeport.

Sedov's services had become interested in Rybolovlev after he had become involved in numerous business scandals, from a bank crash in Cyprus to an accident in a potash mine in the Ural Mountains, where soon after he had sold it, large sinkholes appeared around nearby Berezniki, a city one thousand kilometres to the east of Moscow, forcing 12,000 residents to evacuate their homes.

The question that intrigued Sedov was how come a small-time lawyer, adrift in a fly-bitten tropical backwater, on a distant edge of the Caribbean, had undertaken a journey to one of the most secretive, most guarded, vaults for art treasures on Earth? What was his motivation when the travel expenses alone must have set him back close to ten thousand dollars?

Sedov wondered if Demitriev hadn't stumbled into something much bigger than a failed real estate development involving a few million dollars swindled by a couple of inept crooks?

He concluded there were two urgent matters to be attended to, first was to quash any scandal that would affect him and his friends in the Kremlin, and second investigate the possibility Simmonds had knowingly or unknowingly become involved in some kind of conduit linked to art treasures, modern or ancient, and for whom.

Russian authorities, like many others, had already been alerted by Interpol after the Spanish National Police, in cooperation with their colleagues in Colombia, had seized pre-Columbian artifacts at Barajas airport in Madrid, which had been looted in Colombia, including a rare Tumaco gold mask, gold figurines and ancient jewellery. Three traffickers were arrested in Spain, whilst Colombian authorities carried out house searches in Bogota seizing other valuable objects. It was one of most important finds in the country's history, a sure sign of a grow traffic of looted objects from archaeological sites across Latin America.

* * *

The owner of the Geneva Freeport, Yves Bouvier, had already been investigated by the French police on charges of fraud and money laundering, following allegations made by Rybolovlev, who had accused Bouvier of ripping him off in an affair linked to art works worth more than two billion dollars, paintings which Bouvier had acquired on his behalf.

Rybolovlev made his fortune after the chaotic collapse of the Soviet Union, by creating Uralkali, a fertiliser producer. He then got out of Russia after selling his stake in the company and relocated to Monte Carlo where he lived in a magnificent penthouse overlooking the principality’s harbour.

The most famous deal Bouvier made on Rybolovlev's behalf was that of Leonardo da Vinci’s Salvator Mundi, acquired in an auction at Sotheby’s New York and for which he billed the oligarch 128 million dollars. In reality Bouvier unknown to the Russian had picked up an outrageous commission of 48 million. Unfortunately Sotheby’s let the cat out of the bag when its director told Rybolovlev the real price, naturally the Russian was furious as he had considered Bouvier a friend.

It all ended happily for Bouvier when the investigation was dropped after the Salvator Mundi fetched 450.3 million dollars at another auction in 2017, making it the most expensive piece of art in history, demolishing Rybolovlev’s accusations of fraud.

Yves Bouvier complained, ‘Dmitry Rybolovlev’s arguments never held up to legal scrutiny and this is the reason why he has not won a single case against me in any jurisdiction. Rybolovlev’s attacks against me had nothing to do with the sale of art. He was trying to artificially depreciate the value of his collection in the midst of his divorce proceeding, to punish me for having refused to corrupt the Swiss judges in his divorce, and to steal my Freeport in Singapore and its technology to build a new one in Vladivostok.’

That wasn’t the case for Rybolovlev, who came under the spotlight of investigators in Monaco, linked to allegations of influence peddling and corrupting government officials, including bribery of the Justice Minister himself who had ordered Bouvier’s arrest.

Vladivostok was the key, Vladimir Putin had announced a free port would be set-up in Vladivostok, which was why Bouvier, dubbed ‘The Freeport King’, had accused Rybolovlev of conspiring to take over his high-security Freeport in Singapore and with his know-how build a similar such facility in Vladivostok.

It was a common event in Russia, Pat Kennedy’s partner Sergei Tarasov had been the victim of a raid on his banking empire, a practice known as *reiderstvo*, illicit acquisition of a business or part of a business, more plainly put the theft of businesses and assets from their legal owners, which in Tarasov’s case had, miraculously, only half succeeded. Tarasov was reinstated, but only after he had fled to Ireland and fought a

legal battle, overcoming a vicious campaign of Black PR after VTB's friends attempted to wrest INI Moscow from his control.

Tarasov was more fortunate than Khodorkovsky who lost his business empire and spent ten years in a Siberian gulag before finally fleeing to Switzerland and the UK. Khodorkovsky's Yukos energy company was dismembered in the early 2000s.

Sergei Tarasov now lived in London and trod a careful path, like the owners of Rosbank—the French bank Societe Générale, complying with the desires of the Kremlin and its cronies in the dangerous world of Vladimir Putin's Russia and its security and intelligence services.

Tarasov's bank was far from the rundown *krushchevki* brick apartment buildings and panel housing, it stood in the heart of Moscow City, next to VTB—Russia's leading bank, amidst a cluster of sparkling skyscrapers overlooking the Moskva River. A business district that had taken two decades to build and now boasted some of Europe's tallest skyscrapers.

He, like Rybolovlev, was one of Russia's 102 billionaires, the fourth-wealthiest cohort in the world, behind Germany, China and the United States. Many of those rich Russians lived overseas, in London, New York and Monaco, far from the grimy primary industries they controlled in the Russian heartland dogged by environmental disaster and lackluster economic growth. They preferred to invest their profits in the City of London or Wall Street, hiding their wealth in any one of

the many offshore havens controlled by Boris Johnson's friends in England's Financial Empire.

Pat Kennedy's friend Sergei Tarasov studiously avoid UK politics, unlike many of his compatriots who had established links with the establishment and its Conservative Party leaders and friends. He equally avoided being an instrument of the malign influence of Russia, spread through the UK with *kompromat* and Black PR—character assassination, fake news, blackmail, the manipulation of public opinion, and a multitude of practices developed by the GRU including intimidation and even murder.

Which did not prevent London courts of law being instrumentalised to rule on hundreds of Russian commercial disputes each year as the British justice system handled litigation and arbitration on behalf of wealthy Russian claimants who could expect no such justice in their homeland.

* * *

Sedov then turned his attention to Pat Kennedy's, file, it was thick and dated back to the banker's first visit to Moscow, at the time the Irishman negotiated the deal between Michael Fitzwilliams's and Sergei Tarasov's respective banks, almost a decade earlier.

Such files were part of Russian life, known as *spravki*, one needed to sell a house, to register with a doctor, to have a telephone installed, to import goods, to export goods, to secure

a passport, to enroll at university, part of a whole mountain of information collected by Russian intelligence agencies.

Spying was a tradition in Russia, dating from the Okhrana, created in 1881 by Czar Alexander III, followed by the Cheka under Dzerzhinski, then the revolutionary and Communist NKVD and KGB, succeeded in the post-Communist Federation by the GRU, FSB and SVR. They spied on everything—businesses, families, friends, in the course of which they collected anything that could serve as Black PR, especially run-ins with the law, divorces, mistresses, lovers, sexual behaviour and anything linked to blackmail or corruption.

* * *

From the Villa Contessa's gatehouse to the French border, just a convenient ten kilometres away, along the sinuous corniche, was Monaco one of Europe's leading tax havens, where movie stars, tennis champions, oligarchs and tech billionaires lived and paid little tax, where INI Private Bank, Pat Kennedy's bank managed trusts, holdings, limited liability companies and limited liability partnerships, along with a host of other structures including sociétés anonymes and sociétés anonymes à responsabilité limitée, Liechtenstein anstalts, Swiss stiftungs and Austrian privatstiftungs.

Pat's 91 metre yacht *Las Indias* lay anchored in the Bay of Monaco, a few cables from Jim Ratcliffe's yacht *Hampshire II*, a dozen metres smaller, not that they were competing, in any

case Ratcliffe was the owner of a second yacht the *Sherpa*, which was a few metres shorter than *Hampshire II*.

Ratcliffe the UK's richest man had recently elected residence in the principality to escape his country's onerous taxation laws.

Monaco was one of Europe's tax havens, a magnet for British, German, Italian and many other EU multi-millionaires, all seeking to pay zero income tax, but still wanting to live in mainland Europe.

France was not alone with its tax haven, which masqueraded as a fairy tale principality run by the Grimaldi family, in fact every major European country had its own. The Germans, Austrians and Swiss had Liechtenstein, the Italians San Marino and Campione, the French besides Monaco had Andorra, the Spanish had Britain's Gibraltar, whilst the Brits had the Channel Islands, Guernsey, Jersey, the Isle of Man, and a whole string of territories across the Caribbean, not forgetting the City of London itself, the world's greatest financial hub through which transits 24/7 astronomical sums of money outside of all governmental control, British or otherwise.

However, Monaco was the only true tax haven in Europe for the rich, without any type of personal income tax, no capital gains tax, no inheritance tax in direct line, which suited Vladimir Babkin down to the ground.

Babkin, was a physical commodity trader, he didn't trade virtual commodities on an electronic exchange in the City of London or on Wall Street, but real cargoes transported on bulk

carriers—loaded in Baltic ports, dry fertilizers, liquid chemicals, produced in Cherepovets in Northern Russia, shipped by rail to Ventspils, to buyers in India or Egypt, or chemicals shipped to South Africa.

From Monaco or London he managed companies in the British Virgin Islands, the Caymans and Seychelles that bought and sold commodities to end users all over the world.

Babkin's business had the advantage of buying from producers at well under market price, which allowed him to offer very attractive prices to buyers.

A cargo of 20,000 tonnes of superphosphate, P2O5, bought at say $250/tonne, an artificially low price, from a Russian producer, by Babkin's company in the British Virgin Islands, then whilst it transited the Mediterranean towards Suez, it was sold to another of Babkin's companies at $300/tonne, arriving in the Indian Ocean where another of his companies in the Seychelles bought it at $320/tonne, before it ended up in Mumbai or Calcutta at a 5% market price discount.

The profit was 1,650,000 dollars less costs. Repeated numerous times for timber, metals, oil and gas, his business represented more than 100 million dollars in profits each year. A sum that enabled him and his friends in Russia to live like kings.

The commodities he traded were part of a vast system designed to skim and launder profits at the expense of Russian shareholders and workers.

Another of his companies dealt in property, Russian state property, which was sold to foreign buyers, his, at rigged prices, then resold to developers at vastly higher prices.

Babkin moved between Monaco and London where his office was situated in the crooked square mile of Mayfair, where front companies with their elegant Georgian town houses bearing brass name plates hid unexplained wealth, in a cosmopolitan city that welcomed investors without looking too closely at the source of their wealth, where it came from and where it went.

CHAPTER 30

THE CAVENDISH HOLDINGS FILE that Demitriev had burgled in Belize City contained the Memorandum and the Articles of Association and other papers relating to the directors, of which there were two—Barry Simmonds and Maria Scmitt. The papers indicated Cavendish was owned by two trusts, one in the Caymans and another in the British Virgin Islands.

The appearance of Scmitt's name initially surprised Demitriev, but after consideration he passed on, it was not unusual that nominee directors were used when registering a company, that is to say fronts, a simply ploy to hide the real beneficial persons.

It was possible and probable that Scmitt's name as used for hundreds of companies as was Simmonds.

On the other hand Cavendish was evidently of some importance since the date of its incorporation corresponded to that of Simmonds' visit to San Sebastian. It was perhaps why he had it locked in his desk drawer together with his passport and the visiting cards, rather than in one of the office filing cabinets as was the case with his other records and documents in the well ordered office of the law firm.

But how was he to discover the purpose of Cavendish Holdings when the primary object of Belize IBCs was absolute

confidentiality, no information was filed on public record relating to a company's owners, directors or shareholders. Such information remained privy to the licensed Registered Agent, in this case Simmonds himself, the internal corporate records such as the Registry of Members, Registry of Directors and the Corporate Minutes and Resolutions, were strictly confidential.

The only documents of Belize IBCs held on public record were the Memorandum and Articles of Association. Those documents did not contain any indication as to the actual beneficial owners, directors or controllers of the company.

Of course there was the caveat, which was naturally ignored, that any offshore venture should never be based on secrecy. That it should not rely on blind assumption of total secrecy, should always be based on legality and able to withstand legal scrutiny even if fully disclosed.

Belize IBCs were required to have a minimum of one shareholder, one director, both of whom could be the same person. There were no requirements to have any Belize-resident directors or shareholders. Foreign individuals or corporations could hold shares in a Belize IBC or act as its directors. Corporate directorship, that is the directors` function in a company executed by another company, was expressly allowed.

Apart from the director, the company was not obliged to appoint any other officers, however it could should it wish so.

* * *

With no other alternative, Demitriev ploughed through Simmonds' note book juggling with the lists of codes, account numbers and abbreviations until he finally managed to track down an account belonging to Cavendish Holdings at the Anglo-Dutch Commonwealth Bank in Roseau, Dominica.

He accessed the account using Simmonds' code, there were few details, a credit of one million dollars on the day Simmonds visited San Sebastian. The same day lesser sums were debited from the account in favour of three beneficiaries: 400,000 dollars to the Cayman trust, the same sum to that in the British Virgin Islands, and 150,000 dollars to an account at a bank in Ibiza. Leaving a balance of 50,000 dollars in the account.

From the first two, trusts, he drew a blank, in any case they were probably buried beneath more layers, on the other hand Ibiza was in Spain and less opaque, a lead worth following up.

The knowledge that Simmonds had been paid one million dollars meant only one thing, Kennedy had paid him for something and it wasn't some budget off-the-shelf company in Belize.

He decided another visit to Maria Scmitt was in order.

CHAPTER 31

JOHN FRANCIS SAW BORIS JOHNSON'S furtive supporters and oligarch friends as defenders of liberty, the liberty to do what they liked. They were defenders of the England's Financial Empire, that run by the City of London and its chain of offshore fiscal paradises.

The motto of England's Financial Empire was 'liberty, peace, and prosperity' which meant the freedom to make profits whilst the masses obeyed and diligently consumed.

The people had been duped, sold a pig in a poke—the idea that Britain would be great again, that it would resist in Churchillian style, fingers up to the world, 'becoming incredibly successful', tearing down regulatory barriers, setting lose the wildest forms of capitalism.

'Fuck business', were Johnson's own words as foreign secretary, that is business in an ordered world.

His backers were oligarchs and their business interests, those that sought to demolish employment rights, property speculators, build offshore tax avoidance structures, trans and supra national businesses, those who wished to transform the UK into a vast freeport, men like Murdoch, Ratcliffe, Harborne, Hoskins, whose interests were offshore and who were the most enthusiastic backers of Brexit.

And Farage, a beer swilling blowhard, a lure, hiding behind a screen of xenophobia and foolishness, was a straw man, a convenient pied piper hired to lead the naïve over the edge.

The British voting public had been palmed off with a factice Churchill, a cigar in his mouth and a tommy gun at the ready, a superhero, defending England, isolated, alone, besiege, single-handed, in a life or death battle against Brussels and its 'nazified', 'sovietised', Eurocrats. They forgot Winston had led the world's greatest, if hard pressed, empire against the Third Reich, an empire hocked up to the ears in US dollars, arms and ships, finishing Hitler off thanks to Uncle Joe Stalin and the sacrifice of millions of Russians.

Johnson camped Churchill, his hero, who he portrayed in his book *The Churchill Factor*, or perhaps as Johnson saw himself *How One Man Made History*, and of whom he said during the 2016 referendum campaign, 'Winston Churchill would have joined me on the battle bus,' which described him to a tee, a Don Quixote, charging into battle aboard a London red bus.

Now with Trump shown the door, Johnson had one friend fewer, looking weaker, threatened by Covid, and having to contend with a new pro-Irish American president.

Johnson's grandiose plans, which promised moonshots, echoing Theresa May's promises that Britain would lead the world into the Fourth Industrial Revolution—with world-beating science and technology, were nothing more than cheap

braggadocio, food for Sky News and Murdoch's tabloid—the Express.

John Francis doubted Theresa May or Johnson knew much about the Fourth Industrial Revolution, which was the successor of earlier revolutions, starting with steam which powered the First, electricity the Second, electronics and IT the Third. And the Fourth—projected to be a fusion of technologies built around artificial intelligence, robotics, genetic engineering, quantum computing, and other sciences.

That was all well and good, but at the time of the First Industrial Revolution much of the world was underdeveloped and poor, perhaps Boris Johnson hadn't noticed, but the UK no longer had a monopoly and nations like China, India and Brazil had not only caught up, but had overtaken the UK in multiple fields. Britannia would soon be wallowing in their wake.

Johnson and his friends raved about British exceptionalism built around the nostalgia of a war and a leader of whom few were left alive to tell the true story, transformed into a cult built around the Cenotaph and the Red Poppy of Picardy—symbolising an even more distant war. Wars that had cost the lives of millions, soldiers, and even more civilians, sacrificed on the altar of vanity, egoism and misplaced national pride.

CHAPTER 32

UNKNOWN TO DEMITRIEV, Sedov was worried, and for good reason, amongst the investors in the Caribbean property venture was Bank Rossiya—owned by the media oligarch Dmitri Lebedev, Yury Kovalchuk and other persons close to Vladimir Putin. VTB had recommended the Caribbean property market as a surefire investment.

Kovalchuk was known as Putin's personal banker, he was also a shareholder of the National Media Group, a powerful pro-Kremlin media empire, headed by Alina Kabaeva, who was romantically linked to Putin, even though the Kremlin denied it.

Putin had warned: 'I have a private life in which I do not permit interference. It must be respected,' deploring, 'those who with their snotty noses and erotic fantasies prowl into others' lives.'

Observers had asked how Kabaeva, an Olympic gymnast, famous for her skills with a ball and a hoop, had become the head of Russia's largest media with a remuneration, according to tax leaks, of ten million dollars a year.

That could have seemed a lot, but compared to Putin's net worth it was nothing. Putin's most vocal critic, Bill Browder, estimated the head of the Kremlin had 'accumulated 200 billion dollars of ill-gotten gains,' describing him as 'one of the richest men in the world'.

Putin was generous to his friends, certain of whom lived on Kamenny Island, situated on the Neva delta, to the north of the centre of Saint Petersburg. An elite residential enclave, it was surrounded by water and gardens, dotted with late czarist period mansions and new luxury properties.

It all started at the beginning of the new millennium when a number of newly rich Petersburgers moved into a new residential complex. They were of course not ordinary Russians, most were members of the privileged close circle of the young new president, Vladimir Putin.

They were the privileged owners of luxury apartments in a new residential complex on Berezovaya allee, built in a neo-19th century St. Petersburg style architecture, in a gated park. What was remarkable was the fact they had not bought them, they were gifts, offered by Russia's new capitalist oligarchy that controlled the Kremlin.

It came after a group of powerful insiders divided the carcass of the defunct Soviet Union between them, in what was effectively the theft, organised on a vast scale, of the Soviet Union's economic and industrial patrimony, the rightful owner of which was the Russian people.

Russia had been the scene of the greatest transfer of wealth ever seen, that of the people's to a handful of oligarchs. It was comparable to the Great Depression which led to a monetary reset when one-third of Americans were financially devastated, and more millionaires were created at that point in time than any other time in American history.

The Russian people had become poorer, a handful of new style robber barons had sprung up, known as oligarchs, very rich businessmen who also exercised political influence.

Included in the small group of highly privileged residents living in a fine 19th century gated residence on Birch Alley were several members of Vladimir Putin's inner circle.

Amongst the close friends and property owning neighbours of the man in the Kremlin were Vasily Shestakov, Arkady Rotenberg, Yuri Kovalchuk, Sergey Fursenko, Viktor Myachin and Nikolai Shamalov, all rich and famous.

One that was less known, in fact not known at all, was Svetlana Krivonogikh, the daughter of a very modest Saint Petersburg family, who, like so many ordinary Russian families at the time had grown up in a very cramped rundown state-

owned apartment as the Soviet Union faded into the mists of time as yet another failed experiment in human history.

Svetlana is said to have studied International Economic Relations at the Saint Petersburg University of Economics and Finance where she graduated in 2000.

At that point in time fortune smiled on Svetlana Krivonogikh. Suddenly she was the owner of an upmarket apartment in a sought after neighbourhood in Saint Petersburg. Not only that she was the owner of other properties in St. Petersburg, Moscow and Sochi worth more than ten million dollars.

Where did the sudden unexplained wealth come from?

Sedov as a Petersburger knew—during the period when Boris Yeltsin ruled post Soviet Russia, Svetlana had a high-placed friend in the city's town hall.

Soon after graduating Svetlana had somehow acquired shares in a number of companies, one of which was Bank Rossiya, where she started work in 2001. The relatively small Bank Rossiya then started to expand rapidly under Yuri Kovalchuk soon after Putin became president. Bank Rossiya was then handed the asset management of the certain subsidiaries of the state-owned gas giant Gazprom—Gazprombank and Gazfond, propelling it into the list of the Russia's top twenty banks.

In 2014, immediately after the annexation of Crimea, Bank Rossiya came under US sanctions. Putin, in an act of symbolic support, opened an account at the bank where he lodged his

salary, saying, ‘The bank, in my opinion, has such a sonorous and symbolic name. It is called Russia.’ It was certainly sonorous as Yuri Kovalchuk, Putin’s close friend, owned almost 40% of the bank’s shares.

Kovalchuk was also co-owner of the Igora Ski Resort, situated to the north of Petersburg, where Putin's daughter Katerina and the son of his friend Kirill Shamalov fêted their wedding in 2013. The other owners included Svetlana Krivonogikh, who owned 75% of the company Ozon which managed Igora, as well as owning the land it stood on and the trademark.

Kovalchuk and his wife still held 25% of the shares whilst Rossiya Bank was the main investor in the ski resort, the revenues of which exceeded ten million dollars in 2019.

Backed by Rossiya Bank, Krivonogikh owned other leisure centres and night clubs in Saint Petersburg. All of which led to the question as to who was behind Krivonogikh’s remarkable rise to riches.

For that it was necessary to go back to 1999, at which time Svetlana frequently—as airline records show, accompanied Vladimir Putin on his flights between St. Petersburg and Moscow as Director of Federal Security under Boris Yeltsin, when Putin was also Third Prime Minister of Russia.

The couple’s relationship had commenced in the early nineties and continued into the early 2000s, during which time Putin served as head of the FSB counterintelligence service, prime minister, and as Russian president. A daughter—Elizaveta

Krivonogikh, was born in 2003, when Putin was campaigning for the first election of his career, unsurprisingly Elizaeta's patronymic is Vladimirovna.

Vladimir Putin frequently appeared in public accompanied by his wife Lyudmila, but in 2013, they announced their divorce. Since then, Elizaveta, who bears a remarkable resemblance with Putin, has lived under a different surname.

In 2014, Svetlana Krivonogikh bought her vast apartment on Kamenny island from a company that was connected to Rossiya Bank, BSK-Saint Petersburg, co-owned by Yuri Kovalchuk and Viktor Myachin. However, certain of the properties and businesses were owned by anonymous offshore companies in Cyprus, the owners of which it was later revealed were the Krivonogikhs.

The Krivonogikhs were also helped out by another of Putin's friends—Sergei Roldugin, the cellist, godfather to Putin's daughter Maria, and a minority shareholder of Rossiya Bank. The Panama Papers revealed that a company in the British Virgin Islands with connections to the Roldugin transferred two loans to the Igora management company in the amount of about three million dollars.

At that time, the main shareholder of Igora was hidden behind an anonymous offshore company in Cyprus with ties to the Krivonogikhs. This same shell company helped Svetlana become the owner of a 37 meter yacht named Альдога.

The total value of all property and business assets owned by the Krivonogikh family was estimated at more than 100 million dollars.

CHAPTER 33

THE NEW YEAR COMMENCED WITH A BANG, the job market boomed, incomes soared and confidence surged. The US economy prospered, the world's stock markets were heading for all-time highs, surfing a wave of blind optimism, generated by the explosive growth of deep and disruptive tech industries, changing the way people lived, consumed and were entertained, at a never before seen speed.

So what went wrong? What chain of events set off a reaction that led to some of the most astonishingly volatile moments in Wall Street history.

It all started in January with reports of a virus in a city unknown to most people in the outside world, Wuhan, where it seemed people ate bats and pangolins.

Almost overnight unreal images from China were making the news headlines as the rest of the world looked on with astonishment. At the same time Chinese authorities mobilised their efforts to contain the epidemic. In Europe and the US social networks buzzed, the reactions were varied, comedians joked, there was much mirth, it provoked little fear or anxiety, news readers and television viewers saw it as a remote passing event.

That changed when the coronavirus leaped from its lair, spreading like wildfire, to South Korea, Europe, then the United States, progressively infecting the rest of the world.

The black swan cast its dark shadow, provoking fear, death and panic as the underlying fragility of the global economy was revealed for what it was—a house of cards built on a mountain of debt.

They are sayings that lightening never strikes twice, disaster likes company, bad things come in twos or threes, well, it was as as if the crown prince of Saudi Arabia hadn't noticed a pandemic was rampaging across the biggest oil consuming economies of the planet when he launched a commodity price war against Russia. Riyadh undercut the price of crude by eight dollars a barrel, unwittingly provoking a market crash of huge magnitude, one that saw prices plunge to negative territory.

The New York stock market suffered its largest one-day drop since the 1987 Black Monday collapse, falling 12% in session.

The chaos that ensued resulted in a planetary stock market crash, the speed of which astonished even Wall Street veterans. By the last week in March, 20% had been wiped off share values, the fastest fall ever into a bear market, coming after the longest bull run in history.

By then Wall Street had seen 26 trillion dollars wiped off its equity markets, three times that during the economic crisis of 2008.

On April 20, oil prices fell below zero, that is to say producers paid buyers to take the oil pumped from their wells for which they no longer had storage space as demand abruptly collapsed. An astonishing situation in a motorised world addicted to gasoline and kerosene.

Individually any one of them—the stock market crash, the oil market rout, the pandemic, lockdowns, quarantines, would have been sufficient to cause serious disruption to any economy, combined on a planetary scale they were to inflict deep long-term damage to the entire world economy.

The West would be hardest hit, as the disaster came at a moment in history when profound changes were taking place, the world stood on the edge of the Fourth Industrial Revolution, one that would transform the global economy, a transformation so vast and multifaceted that it was impossible to anticipate the depth and scope of its effects.

The advances in the power of technology were so overwhelming that it was virtually impossible to imagine its future applications.

Today, a common tablet used for reading, for viewing Netflix, with internet access and communications, has the same power as 5,000 first generation desktop PCs, while the cost of storing knowledge and data has become almost negligible.

At the same time, however, the economy had not been generous in spreading its rewards. Prior to the financial crisis that began in 2008, the global economy grew at about 5% a

year, which should have allowed billions of people to escape poverty. But the impact of that crisis left growth in the doldrums, between 3% and 3.5% annually.

In the US the very rich became much richer, the top 1% owned 50% of the nation's wealth, the bottom 80% a mere 7%. A phenomena replicated to different degrees in almost every country, including India and China.

It was little wonder that very small poorer countries like Belize suffered, it was little wonder that the Ambergris Golf Resort had gone bust, leaving the incomplete concrete foundations and rusting reinforcing bars of what should have been luxury condos, a golf and country club pointing to an empty sky, surrounded by wild tropical vegetation that had reclaimed the site, entwining the ruins with its creepers, monuments to lost hopes.

How long would it be before countries like Belize and their tourist industry rediscovered their past lustre?

CHAPTER 34

THE FUTURE WAS BEGINNING to have a new meaning to Pat Kennedy, to start was his project to develop a human compatible DeepMind machine, one that would leave humanity in control as science went into exponential growth, where the idea of an AI takeover was no longer a far fetched scenario, one in which AI could became the dominant form of intelligence on Earth, surpassing humanity, taking over the planet.

What had once been a dream was now reality, not some abstract future, but in Pat’s own new future, one that no man before him could have ever dreamed of.

But what if AI led to human extinction? Certain scientists, such as Stephen Hawking and Stuart Russell, feared that when AI gained the ability to re-design itself at an ever-increasing rate, it would overtake humans, who clever as they thought they were, required thirty years to accumulate the ability to exploit their collective knowledge painfully accumulated over millennium.

This was not an option for Pat Kennedy who now planned to be part of that future.

There were obstacles, OpenAI, a competitor of Alphabet's DeepMind, founded by Elon Musk, estimated the amount of computing power used by the largest deep learning projects had been increasing exponentially with a doubling-time of 3.4

months, however, new chips, architecture and technologies, would overcome obstacles which had rendered Moore's law, which dated from 1965, obsolete.

As always men would find answers, at least that was the way it had been.

Pat had seen how science had opened the path to Galenus, now it would serve him to start build his new world. He had two priorities first was LifeGen Pharmaceuticals in Ireland, then Ciudad Salvator Mundi.

CHAPTER 35

ALTHOUGH HENRIQUE'S ANCESTORS were Portuguese, he knew almost nothing of pre-Columbian civilisations. Growing up in Macau in an old Portuguese family, apart from their language and traditions, he had received an essentially Chinese education onto which was grafted his higher education in London and the influence of Hong Kong, the former British colony, which lay less than an hour away on the hydrofoil ferry across the Pearl River, a city where he had lived and worked until his sudden flight to Brazil.

Henrique had a series of business meetings in Mexico City with various bankers as part of his getting to know the Latino banking world. He was familiar with the major banks present in Mexico, the most important of which was the BBVA, a Spanish bank, one of the largest banking institutions in the world, with a strong presence in the rest of the Americas, then there was the Santander, another Spanish bank, followed by HSBC and Deutsche Bank. The presence of foreign owned banks seemed incongruous, but like in many other countries it was an historical phenomena, as in Hong Kong.

A couple of days later he was joined by Mike Watson who had flown in from Cancun, he was on the trail of the Russians who he believed were responsible for the deaths of Vishnevsky, Wallace and the disappearance of Simmonds and hoped to learn more about Demitriev from his contacts in Mexico City.

Henrique had decided to let Watson tag along, the reporter knew the terrain and could guide him in his search. He had already learnt in Brazil that you couldn't count on the police or the law, all of which was riddled with self interest and corruption.

The last thing Belize needed was the media frightening off the few tourists and investors still around with lurid stories of murder, disappearances and bankrupt real estate projects. Besides, the police department was undermanned, underpaid and overwhelmed by daily crime as the Covid pandemic ushered in a new era of uncertainty, poverty and despair.

He had booked Watson into his hotel, the Four Seasons on Avenida Paseo de Reforma, agreeing to foot the bill, as part of their unspoken deal, as Watson's budget didn't stretch to that class and Henrique didn't want to be running all over the city, taking unnecessary risks in what was reputed to be a most dangerous place.

It was the weekend and Mike Watson proposed they visit the archaeological sites in the city centre, near to the Metropolitan Cathedral of the Assumption, which had been constructed over the Templo Mayor, one of the main temples of the Aztec capital, Tenochtitlan, by Cortes, situated on what was now the Plaza de la Constitucion.

New excavations had unearthed part of an Aztec tower of human skulls predating the conquest. The work carried out by the National Institute of Anthropology and History had

uncovered the facade and eastern side of the tower, as well as 119 human skulls of men, women and children, in addition to the hundreds already found.

The tower, approximately five meters in diameter, had been first discovered in 2017, and was believed to be part of the Huey Tzompantli, a huge array of skulls embedded in the structure that had struck fear into the Spanish conquistadors when they captured the city under Hernan Cortes in 1521.

The tower, thought to have been constructed in three phases between 1486 and 1502, was one of the most remarkable discoveries in the city.

The skulls included not only those of warriors, but also women and children and raised many questions about human sacrifice in the Aztec Empire. Probably captives destined for sacrificial ceremonies, gifts for the gods or even personifications of deities themselves.

The tower stood on the corner of the shrine of Huitzilopochtli, the Aztec god of the sun, war and human sacrifice, only part of which had been excavated.

The tower was almost certainly one of the skull edifices mentioned by Andres de Tapia, a Spanish soldier who had accompanied Cortes during the conquest of Mexico in the 1521. In his account of the campaign, de Tapia said he counted tens of thousands of skulls at what became known as the Huey Tzompantli.

The grim discovery told Henrique much about the violent past of Mexico, it raised many questions, but he knew that other civilisations, like those that had given birth to his own mixed ancestry, had been as equally blood thirsty, but in different ways.

* * *

That evening they dined at Bellinghausen, a restaurant in the Zona Rosa not far from their hotel. Mike had probably chosen it for the benefit of Henrique, one of its specialties was roast suckling pig which first time visitors to Mexico City seemed to appreciate. They dined at a table on the terrace in a quiet corner with one of Mike's friends, Victor Sanchez, a well-known journalist and contributor to La Politica and El Heraldo, he was specialised in international affairs and had spent several years as a foreign correspondent in Moscow.

After drinks and small talk they got down to the subject of Demitriev. 'As you known he's Russia's liaison man in Belize, they have no embassy or consulate there, Moscow is represented by the Mexican Embassy,' Sanchez reminded Henrique. 'He is in fact a Russian intelligence agent, like a lot of commercial attachés in embassies, his job is to spy for the GRU or one of the other agencies.'

'GRU?' asked Henrique.

'That's one of Russia's intelligence agencies, officially know as the Main Directorate.'

Henrique nodded.

‘Demitriev is a former Spetsnaz GRU officer, who in theory works closely with Russia’s other security agencies, the FSB and SVR and their many fronts, companies run by former high ranking officers that offer security-related services.’

He explained that technically the FSB’s domain was domestic, internal matters, but it had become increasingly active overseas.

‘That’s where our late friend Vishnevsky comes in. He was a former FSB colonel, whose relations with Demitriev were complicated as the FSB has a number of prerogatives, certain relatively minor, for example the issuance of international travel documents, such as passports and visas, a source of much friction between the different agencies.’

In the days of the Soviet Union, the KGB had been a one-stop shop, which handled everything from foreign espionage to domestic security, but that changed when Boris Yeltsin dismantled the KGB, eventually dividing its duties between the FSB and the SVR. Those two agencies were complemented by the GRU, the intelligence branch of the Russian military.

The problem arose when the prerogatives of the fiercely competitive agencies overlapped and turf wars erupted and although Putin looked favourably on the Federation’s intelligence agencies, he often played them off one against the other.

Henrique had observed the same political manipulations in China, where interests with the party and those of powerful cliques swayed decisions.

‘We should never forget the man in the Kremlin is a creation of the KGB of which he was a career officer from 1975 until the dissolution of the Soviet Union.’

Putin, thanks to his mentor Anatoly Sobchak, a former mayor of Saint Petersburg, and a series of serendipitous opportunities, his path crossed that of Boris Yeltsin, which led to his appointment as head of the FSB, then prime minister and vice president, placing him firmly on the path to destiny and absolute power.

‘It’s not surprising that many former intelligence officers are members of Putin’s inner circle, and it’s not by chance they became powerful oligarchs and politicians, forming a clan around him, welded together by common interests and loyalty, known as the *siloviki*, or strongmen.

‘So you see,’ Sanchez explained, ‘in this part of the world each of those agencies is involved in one way or another in the corruption and money-laundering operations run on by or on behalf of the Russian elite’s different cliques.

‘Each of the agencies maintains shady links with local criminal organisations, which can be instrumentalised if and when necessary, like here in Mexico, where the cartels are involved in their dirty work, like assassinations.’

‘We believe Demitriev is closer to the SVR, the civilian counterpart of the GRU. Operating under diplomatic cover, his role is to channel funds to different British think-tanks, trusts and other actors backing Brexit.’

‘Our Embassy in Moscow is well informed,’ Sanchez continued. ‘Anyone with one hundred euros or so can download all kinds of information from Yandex, that’s the Russian equivalent of Google. There are sites where you can get anything from passport data bases to military academy records, and for similar ‘fee’ a quality fake passport, driving license, marriage certificate and even business registration documents.

‘So much for secrecy in Vladimir Putin’s Russia,’ Mike Watson added with a knowing smile.

‘Today, there is an unlimited supply of data available on the market—credit card records and even mobile phone tracking data, so be careful my friend, you are being followed by someone somewhere.’

‘So what does Demitriev do in Mexico?’ asked Henrique.

‘Well for one thing he’s known for his links to the cartels. Besides that Mexico is a good place to operate, between the US and Central America. Cancun has been a stopping off point for Russians going to or coming from Havana or Caracas for decades.’

‘I see.’

Henrique was too young to know much about Chavez, let alone the Bay of Pigs and the Cuban missile crisis.

‘Moscow has used Mexico for their operations in the Caribbean for decades. Today it’s more to do with money laundering than anything else. Russian tourist arrivals have grown considerably with direct flights from Moscow, the better off ones are buying upmarket property in Cancun. Soft power,’ he told them with a laugh.’

Mike repeated the story of Vishnevsky and Wallace and asked why they had been killed.

‘You know life here and Central America is cheap. People get in the way and they’re eliminated,’ Sanchez told him with a grim smile. ‘I’d say they’d fallen foul of some powerful and very unpleasant people in Moscow and Demitriev’s friends here in Mexico or Belize did the rest.’

Henrique said nothing, he absorbed the information.

‘Places like Cancun attract a lot of tourists and criminal organisations follow the money trail. It’s the same for Russian tourists, the kind that take the thirteen hour flight from Moscow have money to spend, some of them a lot of money … to spend … or to hide.’

‘What about our friend Simmonds?’

‘From what Mike tells me Simmonds was in on a real estate deal with the Russians. So, same conclusion. People in this part

of the world disappear all the time.' he replied with a shrug. 'If I was you, a representative of a large international banking group, I wouldn't move around without close protection.'

Henrique took a good slug of his wine and wondered what kind of business Kennedy had gotten him into.

* * *

Henrique was discovering the world had become an unsafer place, not only his home in China where 96% of Hongkongers considered their city was no longer the safe and free place they had lived in before the introduction of the new laws imposed by Beijing.

It was estimated three million Hong Kong residents planned to emigrate to the UK, Canada and Australia with up to half a million of them planning to move to Britain during the first three years of a UK government scheme set to start in January 2021.

It was bad news for Kennedy, but he was a businessman, he had survived the City & Colonial grab under Cameron's government, the Kremlin's attack on Sergei Tarasov's Moscow end of INI, and now he would survive the changes in Hong Kong. Who could ignore a market of one and a half billion customers in a country about to dominate the world and conquer the stars.

A new flood of immigrants from Hong Kong with money, an education and professional skills would be an injection that

would of course boost Johnson's ambition to compete as a 'sovereign' state. What it meant for grassroot Brits and how many of the new arrivals were Beijing's moles and sleepers was another story.

* * *

Unknown to Henrique, Arkady Demitriev had just arrived in Geneva from Moscow carrying a Czech passport. The Czech Republic being a member of the Schengen area was visa free and he was out of the airport in fifteen minutes, heading downtown to a hotel where he had a reservation booked in his new name—Milan Hasek.

The previous evening, reviewing the meagre evidence he had gleaned from Simmonds office in Belize, Demitriev had flipped through the precious address book containing the lawyer's codes. Regretfully, he had concluded it would require an army of lawyers and accountants to track down each company and each bank account to unravel the links to the real owners.

As he closed the book and threw it onto the table in his spartan room at the GRU residence where he had been lodged in Moscow, a thin slip of paper dropped out and floated down onto the worn carpet.

He picked it up, it was a fading cash receipt from Payot Genéve Rive Gauche, rue de la Confédération 7, 1204 Geneva, Switzerland.

Holding it under the room's dim table lamp he could just make out the details, its date corresponded with that of Simmonds visit to the city. He googled the address, it was a bookstore.

Three books were listed on the receipt with reference numbers, titles, prices and taxes. The titles were abbreviated Aztec Maya, Conquista and Codeces.

It was the last one that caught his attention, the most expensive, priced at 76 Swiss Francs.

The first thing he did on arrival at his hotel on Place Isaac-Mercier in downtown Geneva was to pay a visit to the bookstore, situated on rue de la Confédération on the Left Bank, a ten minute walk from the hotel.

The bookstore was much bigger than he had expected and after a little searching he made his way to the second level where he found the history section, organised by region. He commenced under Central America, where a wide selection of books were available on Aztec and the Maya civilisations along with histories of the Conquista.

Perusing the titles he selected a book entitled The Aztec Codeces, which bore the same bookshop reference number corresponded to Simmonds' receipt as well as the same price.

He flipped through the pages, stopping at the images, some of which recalled the conference he had attended at the Getty

Center in Santa Monica, when he had covertly followed Anna Basurko and her friend.

He closed the book headed for the checkout desk and then to a nearby cafe where he sat down, ordered a coffee and started a closer examination of the book.

Slowly the pieces came together. If Simmonds had visited the Freeport and flown from Geneva to Madrid he couldn't have transported anything big or heavy, that coupled with the fact he had returned to Belize without any accompanying baggage, indicated that whatever he discovered, if he had discovered something, could have been carried in his briefcase or overnight bag.

It would have been valuable, which explained the million paid into the Cavendish Holdings account at the Anglo-Dutch Commonwealth Bank in Dominica.

Perhaps Simmonds had discovered a codex, in any case it was something Demitriev would try to establish when he headed for Monte Carlo, where according to the latest information Kennedy's yacht was anchored.

CHAPTER 36

ANNA MOVED TO DEE'S PLACE in Guethary, in the French Basque Country, 40 kilometres to the north of San Sebastian—her home town also known as Donostia. The magnificent property he had bought to be nearer Anna, hadn't really seduced her.

Anna protested she was a Donostiarra—as the Basques of Donostia called themselves. She wasn't a nationalist, but was nevertheless proud of her Basque origins. In any case she wasn't ready to quit her beautiful home town with all its amenities, traditions and rich cultural life.

That was before the pandemic struck, hitting San Sebastian hard, and Anna quietly changed her mind, moving to Dee's place in Guethary, as he did too, abandoning Paris and its over-easy attitude to the virus, at least momentarily

Dee's vast Belle Époque villa was set in a splendid six hectare park with a spectacular view of the Pyrenean valley landscape. It lay on the edge of Guethary, a small picturesque seaside town situated between St Jean de Luz and Biarritz, an exclusive spot favoured discerning French fashionistas, showbiz and other personalities. It was quiet, sedate, far from the bling of the Côte d'Azur and its tourists.

The reason Dee, a best selling author, had bought the villa had been of course to do with Anna, who had already warned him

she had no intention of moving across the border. The property, fit for a lady, had been part of his plan to convince her that theirs was not just a passing affair.

Guethary, just a thirty minute drive from San Sebastian by the autoroute and was well served with several daily regular flights from Biarritz Airport to Paris and London, with nearby San Sebastian Airport serving Madrid and Barcelona.

The large house seemed more than a little big for Dee and Anna, but its the high walls and cameras gave them a sense of tranquility and security whilst they enjoyed a game of tennis, a swim in its heated pool or just relaxing in the gardens during the lockdowns in France and over the border in Spain.

It was a spot favoured by amateur pilots, and the couple were used to seeing ULMs and hang gliders in the sky above them taking advantage of the ascending air currents to enjoy the spectacular Pyrenean panoramas. That summer if they had been more observant they would have remarked an increase in the number of flights over the villa, especially those of silent drones, two hundred metres or so above the tall trees, filming their movements, controlled from a pickup parked on the edge of the village, on the orders of Jacques Gautier, the Honorary Vice Consul of Russia in Biarritz, one of the GRU's willing helpers.

In addition magnetic GPS tracking devices had been positioned in the wheel wells of their vehicles, unknown to

Anna and Dee they had become persons of interest, targets of Milan Hasek, otherwise known as Arkady Demitriev.

APOLOGIES

Belize is a pleasant small laid back country, situated on the northern edge of the Caribbean, struggling to survive in these trying times. In spite of being dogged by safety problems it has much natural beauty which together with the legacy of the Maya civilisation, will, if given the time and luck, provide it with the means to succeed and join the other former islands and outposts of the British Empire by becoming a prosperous offshore tourist destination and financial centre.

All that I have written here is pure fiction … unless otherwise stated, or not ….

I hope you, my reader, will forgive me for my endless lacuna related to facts and omissions as well as my usual grammar, syntax and spelling derivation. All of which, I fear, would take another lifetime to rectify, which I don't have given my advancing years, that plus the fact I have so many other stories to tell and observations to make on our world. Perhaps one day Google and AI will find a way to remove this burden from story tellers, who like me are not sufficiently applied, as my headmaster once told me.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

This book could not have been written without the data and information published on the Internet and in the world press collected over a period of years, starting in 2000, when I wrote Offshore Islands, and Pat Kennedy was launched on his initially precarious international career.

I have trawled numerous British, Irish, US, Russian, French, Spanish, Chinese, Israeli, Colombian newspapers, news blogs and specialist Internet sites, and books (authors' cited). And of course Wikipedia.

During this period I have collected information during my visits to the USA, China, Hong Kong, Macau, Indonesia, India, Dubai, Thailand, Cambodia, Libya, Egypt, Kenya, Tanzania, Senegal, Mali, Morocco, Mexico, Colombia, Panama, Brazil, Guatemala, Belize, Honduras, the Philippines, the UK, Germany, Belgium, France, Spain and Italy. To this I have added my experience in other parts of the world, notably Ireland, Australia, New Zealand, South Africa, Malaysia, Singapore, Brunei, Taiwan, Japan, Burma, Switzerland, Algeria, Russia, Scandinavia, the Baltic Countries, Poland, Hungary, the countries of ex-Yugoslavia, Greece, Turkey, Russia, Turkmenistan, Jordan, Syria, Israel, Egypt, the Caribbean, Central and South America.

I present my thanks and excuses to all the willing and unwilling contributors to the information included in this book,

I am not the first to tread in the footsteps of Jack London, using the information supplied to us from those who convey it. I have tried to verify all the facts, but this is an impossible task. In my humble opinion most data reflects real events and the opinions of the vast majority of persons affected, directly or indirectly, by the multiple events and crises that constitute our collective existence.

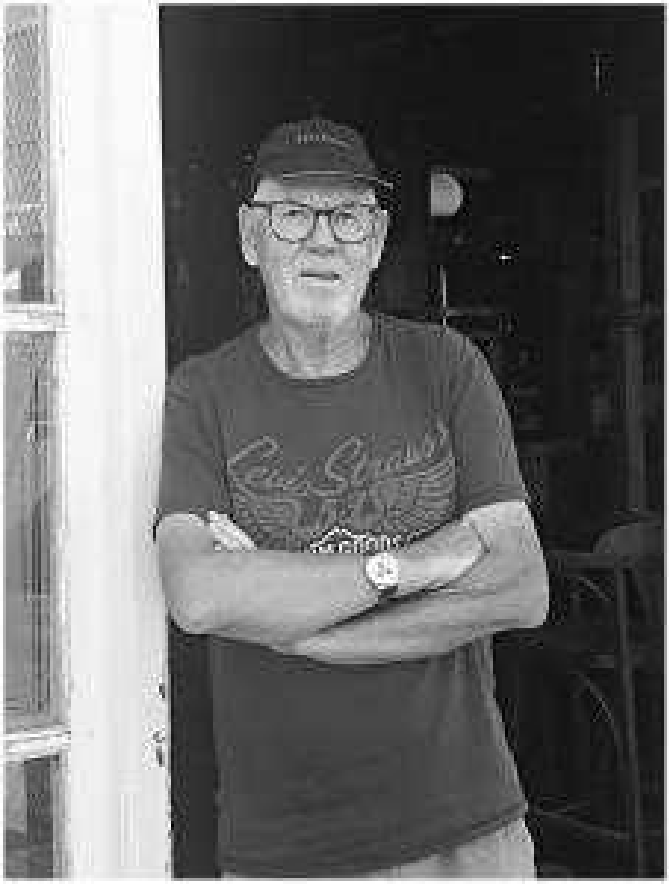
This story is a serialised novel of events, real or not, where the fictitious characters are fictitious, and where the real characters, such as Vladimir Putin, Nicolas Maduro, Donald Trump, Boris Johnson and Emanuel Macron, are real.

The story of 2000, and its sequels in 2010-2012, 2013, 2015, 2017, 2018, 2019 and 2020, are recounted in my other tales.

With my very sincere thanks to all contributors, direct and indirect, knowing and unknowing, willing and unwilling.

John Francis Kinsella

Paris, January 1, 2021



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Translations

Le Point de Non Retour

The Sorrow of Europe

The Temple of Solomon

Jean Sibelius A biography

Understanding Architecture

L'île de l'ouest

In the works

A Biography of Patrick Wolfe (Fiction)

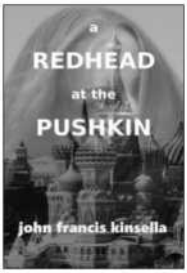
Ibiza—Book IV of The Gilgamesh Project, will be published in early 2021.

What happens in Egypt?

What are the effects of the Galenus formula on Pat Kennedy and John Francis?

Does Demitriev discover who Maria Scmitt is?

Does Mike Watson find out who killed Vishnevsky?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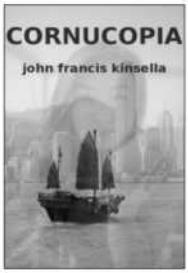
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2009-2010 the crisis bites
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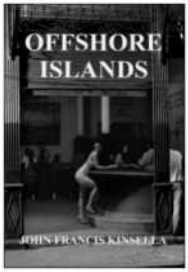
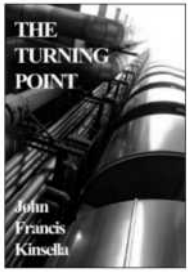

OFFSHORE
ISLANDS
JOHN FRANCIS KINSELLA


THE
TURNING
POINT
John
Francis
Kinsella